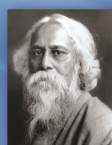




NON-VIOLENCE IS THE BEST PRACTICE
- Mahatma Gandhi

Social Science

Part - I



HISTORY

A Textbook for Class X



One horn Rhino is the pride of Assam
Poachers are enemies of Assam



SECONDARY EDUCATION DEPARTMENT
GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

SECONDARY EDUCATION DEPARTMENT
GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

Cleanliness, Hygiene and Sanitation

For students :

- Wash your hands with soap and water before touching any food item. Also instruct and encourage the other members of your family to do the same.
- Maintain proper cleanliness in and around your house / school premises. Observe the cleanliness in your neighbourhood as well.
- Wash and clean the dishes before serving any food on them to kill germs.
- See that the vegetables, green leaves, etc. are washed properly before cooking.
- Wash the fruits, vegetables, etc. properly before consuming.
- Cut and trim your nails, hair, etc. on a regular basis.
- Keep the surrounding and drains of your house clean so that mosquitoes and other germ carrying insects don't breed on them.
- Never keep food and drinking water uncovered.
- Always drink filtered and purified water.
- A proper drainage system in your residence as well as school premises should be built and maintained properly.
- Water should not be allowed to gather and log in and around your house and school premises. Logged water serves as breeding place for mosquitoes, flies etc.

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Cleanliness, Hygiene and Sanitation

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- Wastes such as animal and human excreta, solid wastes, domestic wastewater etc. may cause health problems if pit latrines, dry toilets, urine-diverting dry toilets, septic tanks are not built and maintained properly. For sewage treatment and excreta management septic tanks are necessary at home and in school compound.
- There should not be any garbage or waste material gathering dump near our residences.
- Lack of sanitation usually results in open defecation and open urination which leads to serious public health issues. Even if toilets are available, people still need to be convinced to refrain from open defecation and to use toilets. Therefore, the need for behavioural change is critical in addition to the provision of toilets. The microorganisms contained in human faeces may enter the body through contaminated food, water, eating and cooking utensils and by contact with contaminated objects. Some fly species are attracted to or breed in faeces. Infectious diseases are transmitted through contact with soil contaminated with faeces and may spread rapidly where open defecation occurs. These infections will contribute to several disease and malnutrition, and therefore also render people more susceptible to other diseases.
- Recycle bins must be placed at various places in schools to promote recycling of waste among students, teachers and other employees. Develop the habit of disposing of waste properly in appropriate bins only.
- Use disinfectant and pest control measures on a regular basis. But pesticides should be kept separately with care.
- Cleanliness, Personal hygiene, Good sanitation provide a clean school environment that nurtures good health.

Social Science

Part-I

HISTORY

Textbook for Class X

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Foreword

Social Science, after being the compulsory subject based on the National Policy of Education, it covers four disciplines—History, Geography, Political Science and Economics. According to the National Policy of Education, now five subjects are compulsory in the Secondary Education level. In case of Assam, students have to study another sixth subject as an Elective subject. To offer one subject as the Elective, students have the option to choose from twenty two number of subjects presently exist in the syllabus of the Board. Apart from these, recently another five vocational subjects have also been included under National Skill Qualification Framework (NSQF). It is worth mentioning that, the Board has provided opportunity to the students to offer History or Geography as the Elective subject, which are also included in the above mentioned twenty two subjects.

The Board has revised the syllabus of Social Science and introduced the new textbook in 2005, keeping in view the importance of the study of History and Geography compulsorily. The textbook of Social Science for Class IX was introduced in the academic year 2015, which has been divided into three parts— Part I- History, Part II- Geography and Part III- Political Science & Economics. Similarly, the another three parts have been introduced in Class X in the academic year 2016. The scopes of the subjects History and Geography have been increased with a view to giving more weightage on Assam History and Assam Geography. By dividing the subject into three parts, it is expected that the students will be benefited from it.

We acknowledge the contributions of all the resource persons engaged in the process of preparation of this book, on behalf of the Board.

We will be very much glad, if the teachers, guardians, students and scholars in the field provide us constructive suggestions for any unexpected mistakes if found in the book, and correcting those in the next editions.

Guwahati

Secretary
Board of Secondary Education, Assam

CONTENTS

Chapter	Subject	Page
Chapter-1	Partition of Bengal and Swadeshi Movement	1
	1.01 The Background of Partition of Bengal	2
	1.02 The Partition of Bengal	4
	1.03 Swadeshi Movement	6
	1.04 Consequences of the Swadeshi Movement	10
	1.05 Swadeshi Movement and National Congress	15
	1.06 Anti Movement Actions of the Government	16
	1.07 The contribution of Swadeshi Movement	16
Chapter-2	Rise of Gandhi and the Freedom Movement of India	20
	2.01 Rise of Gandhi	20
	2.02 Rowlatt Act	22
	2.03 <i>Satyagraha</i> or Non-violence movement	23
	2.04 The Jallianwala Bagh Massacre	23
	2.05 Khilafat Movement	24
	2.06 The Non-Cooperation Movement	24
	2.07 End of Non-Cooperation Movement	26
	2.08 Simon Commission	26
	2.09 Civil Disobedience Movement	27
	2.10 Gandhi – Irwin Pact	28
	2.11 The Second Round Table Conference	29
	2.12 Restarting of the Civil Disobedience Movement	29
	2.13 Communal Award	29
	2.14 Formation of Congress Ministries	30
	2.15 Resignation of Congress Ministries	30
	2.16 Demand for Pakistan	30
	2.17 Individual <i>Satyagraha</i>	30
	2.18 Cripps Mission	31
	2.19 Quit India Movement	31
	2.20 Indian National Army	33
	2.21 Declaration of June 3, 1947	35
	2.22 Indian Independence Act, 1947	35
	2.23 Birth of Independent India	35

Chapter	Subject	Page
Chapter-3	Anti-British Rising and Peasant Revolts in Assam	38
	3.0 Anti-British uprising in Assam	38
	3.1 Revolt of 1857 in India and its impact on Assam	41
	3.2 Rise of Peasant's Revolt in Assam	47
	3.3 Peasant Revolt of Lower Assam	50
	3.4 Ethnic (Tribal) Revolt	54
	3.5 Revolt in Manipur	56
Chapter-4	Indian Freedom Movement and National Awakening in Assam	59
	4.00 Growth of Assamese Nationalism	59
	4.01 Asomiya Bhasa Unnati Sadhini Sabha	60
	4.02 Jonaki Age	61
	4.03 Assam Chatra Sanmilan	62
	4.04 Ryat Sabha	62
	4.05 Ahom Sabha	63
	4.06 Jorhat Sarbajanik Sabha	63
	4.07 Assam Association	64
	4.08 Assam Provincial Congress Committee	66
	4.09 Swadeshi Movement and Assam	67
	4.10 The Non-Cooperation Movement and Assam	68
	4.11 Civil Disobedience Movement and Assam	70
	4.12 Quit India Movement and Assam	71
	4.13 Ministry of Gopinath Bordoloi	73
Chapter-5	Cultural Heritage of India and North East Region	79
	5.01 The source of Cultural Heritage of India	79
	5.02 Literature	82
	5.03 Architecture	83
	5.04 Sculpture	84
	5.05 Paintings	85
	5.06 Music and Dances	86
	5.07 Yoga Culture	87
	5.08 North East	87
	5.09 Assam	90
	5.10 Literature	91
	5.11 Religion	92
	5.12 Art and Paintings	93
	5.13 Sculptures	94
	5.14 Architecture	94
	5.15 Folk Culture	95



CHAPTER-1

PARTITION OF BENGAL (1905-1911 A.D.) AND SWADESHI MOVEMENT

KEY POINTS

- The Background of Partition of Bengal.
- Partition of Bengal
- Swadeshi Movement
- Consequences of Swadeshi Movement
- National Literature
- National Education
- The contribution of women in Swadeshi Movement.
- Rise of National Industry
- Establishment of Muslim League.
- Swadeshi Movement and Indian National Congress.
- Anti-movement activities of the Government
- The contribution of Swadeshi Movement.

Introduction :

The partition of Bengal is one of the most important chapters in the freedom struggle of India. This partition, which occurred during the reign of Lord Curzon (1899-1905), is a historic event in the political history of India. The creation of two states by dividing the vast Bengal province stirred

a national struggle against the British rule in whole India. This event is known as the second important political upheaval in India after the Sepoy Mutiny in 1857.

In the last part of the 19th century and in the beginning of the 20th century the national movement became very strong in the Bengal province. This consciousness and uprising among the people put the British government in a dilemma and to suppress this national uprising, Lord Curzon created a new province named 'Eastern Bengal and Assam' by adjoining East Bengal to Assam. On the other hand by keeping the remaining west parts of Bengal with Bihar and Orissa (Odisha) as before, another province was continued as West Bengal. The whole country stood united on the protest to this partition. It created a new era in the uprising of national sentiment in every Indian. In reality the movement against the British policy of partition of Bengal was the first active national struggle in all Indian perspective.

1.01. The Background of Partition of Bengal

The British government introduced Regulating Act in 1773, and upgraded the post of the Governor of Bengal Presidency to the level of Governor General. By this introduction, the two Governors of Bombay and Madras were brought under the control of the Governor of Fort William. Since the area under the Governor of Fort William had become vast, the governing of Bengal province was given to a Lieutenant Governor. Again it had not been possible to continue good governance in the Bengal province by just one Lt. Governor, as this province covered a vast area of North and East India.

According to the Allahabad treaty (1765 A.D.) between the Moghul emperor Shah Alam and Robert Clive, the East India Company won political authority on Bihar and Orissa along with Bengal and these three regions were included in the province of Bengal.

After the sepoy mutiny in 1857, the British took steps to reform the Indian administration and the partition of Bengal was also included in this process. After the discussion between the government of England and India the decision was taken to disjoin a vast area of East India from Bengal. Keeping this view in mind, on 7th February 1874 the state of Assam was created by including six districts from Brahmaputra valley (Goalpara, Kamrup, Nagaon, Darrang, Lakhimpur and Sivasagar) with Khasia-Jayantiya

Hills, Naga Pahar, Garo Pahar, Cachar and Srihatta (Total area 54, 100 sq. mile, population 41,50,000). The post of a Chief Commissioner was created for this new state and Colonel R.H. Keatings was given the charge of the state (1874-78). According to some historians it was the first step

The British colonialism was established all over India starting from 2nd tenure of Robert Clive (1765) to the rule of Lord Dalhousie (1848-1856) and Calcutta, Mumbai and Madrass became the three main administrative centres of East India Company. The highest administrator of each centre was given the post of President and the administrative system was popularly known as Presidency under the President.

in the process of partition of Bengal. In the process of this partition two British officers helped Lord Curzon. One was Andrew Fraser, the then Chief Commissioner of Madhya Pradesh and the other was J. Bamfylde Fuller, the Chief Commissioner of Assam. In 1901 A.D. Fraser gave proposal to Lord Curzon to change the geographical boundary of Madhya Pradesh and Bengal.

The famine broke-out in Orissa (a part of Bengal) in 1866 A.D. and around 10000 people lost their lives. Viceroy Lord Northbrook (1872-76 A.D.) by showing his administrative caliber put the proposal of the partition of Bengal before the government of England.

Fraser mentioned the increasing population of Bengal which was 7.8 crore at that time and he proposed to disjoin Orissa and Sambalpur from Bengal and to annex to Madhya Pradesh. At the same time Fuller also proposed to annex Chattagram to Assam with a view to expanding the tea business. Lord Curzon studied two proposals of them and finding it pragmatic, he expressed his desire to implement these.

The following regions went under the British empire in India – the valley of Brahmaputra (through the treaty of Yandabu on 24th February, 1826), Cachar in 1832, Khasi Hills in 1833, Jaintia Hills in 1835, the province of Motok and Sadiya in 1839, the province of Khamti in 1843, the province of Singfoo in 1843, the area of Angami Naga Hills in 1854. These regions were controlled by the Lt. Governor of Bengal up to 1874. Then the area of Bengal was 2,53,000 sq. mile and total population was 4 crore 60 lacs.

1.02. The Partition of Bengal

When Andrew Fraser was appointed as Lt. Governor of Bengal in 1903, Viceroy Lord Curzon directed him to make a plan for re-demarcation of the boundary of the province. Then Andrew Fraser made a slight change in the previous suggestion of William E. Ward and made a plan for the partition of Bengal. He submitted his plan to Lord Curzon on 28th March, 1903. He suggested to annex Dhaka, Chattagram and Rajshahi (total area of 15 Districts) to neighbouring state of Assam. On 1st June, 1903 Viceroy Lord Curzon prepared a detail proposal of the partition of Bengal, by discussing with Hebert Risley, the Secretary of State, Govt. of India.

With a view to expanding tea business, through sea routes also, the European tea planters put proposals to expand the boundary of Assam up to Chattagram. Keeping this view in mind Chief Commissioner William. E. Ward (1894-96 A.D.) in his second tenure put proposals to annex Chattagram, two districts of Dhaka and Maimonsing to Assam. But this proposal would not be implemented due to chaotic political milieu of that period.

This proposal was officially accepted by the British government and it was recognised as, 'the Minute on Territorial Re-distribution in India.' Since this proposal was officially declared by Hebert Risley, the Secretary of State on 6th Dec, 1903, it was known as 'Risley papers.' The process of bifurcation of Bengal and to annex one part of it into Assam is historically known as the historical 'Partition of Bengal'.

The area of three territories Dhaka, Chattagram and Rajshahi was about 106540 sq. mile and total population was 31 million, out of which 18 millions were Muslims and 12 millions were Hindus.

It was said that the vast Bengal province could not be ruled smoothly under a Lt. Governor and accordingly the plan was taken to create a province named 'Eastern Bengal and Assam', by annexing 15 districts of North and East Bengal to Assam. On the other hand the Bengal province was to be continued with the remaining western parts of the province and by annexing Bihar, Orissa and Chotanagpur. Dhaka was to be the capital of the proposed 'Eastern Bengal and Assam', and this proposed state had a population of around three crores and ten lacs. Among this Muslim population was 1.8 crores and Hindus were 1.2 crores. On the other hand

Calcutta was to be the capital of the proposed 'Bengal province' and it had a population of around 5.4 crores. Among this Hindus were 4.2 crores and Muslims were just 90 thousands. But in comparison to the people of Bihar and Orissa, the Bengalis were minority.

Though Lord Curzon proposed to make the territory of Bengal smaller and the territory of Assam bigger for a smooth administration, the hidden agenda behind it also came on the surface. Because the unity between Hindu and Muslim farmers and labourers was a threat for the British, they planned to break the unity by division. Hebert Risley's letter to Lord Curzon mentioned, 'The United Bengal is a big force, the partition will destroy this big unity.' So the hidden purpose behind the partition of Bengal was to decimate the Hindu Muslim unity. To meet this vested interest, communal feelings were needed to be spread.

Since Bengal was considered to be the centre of Indian nationalism, through the partition of Bengal it was planned to divide the province and to make the Hindu Bengalis and intellectuals a minority in both the states. The real motive of Lord Curzon was to strengthen the British empire in India by weakening the politically conscious Hindu-Bengalis and thus to resist the growth of Indian nationalism. Through this plan he tried to increase loyalty of the Muslim who were politically less conscious, and thus planned to sow the seed of communalism in Indian society. At the same time he took it as a weapon to dominate the growing anti British extremists.

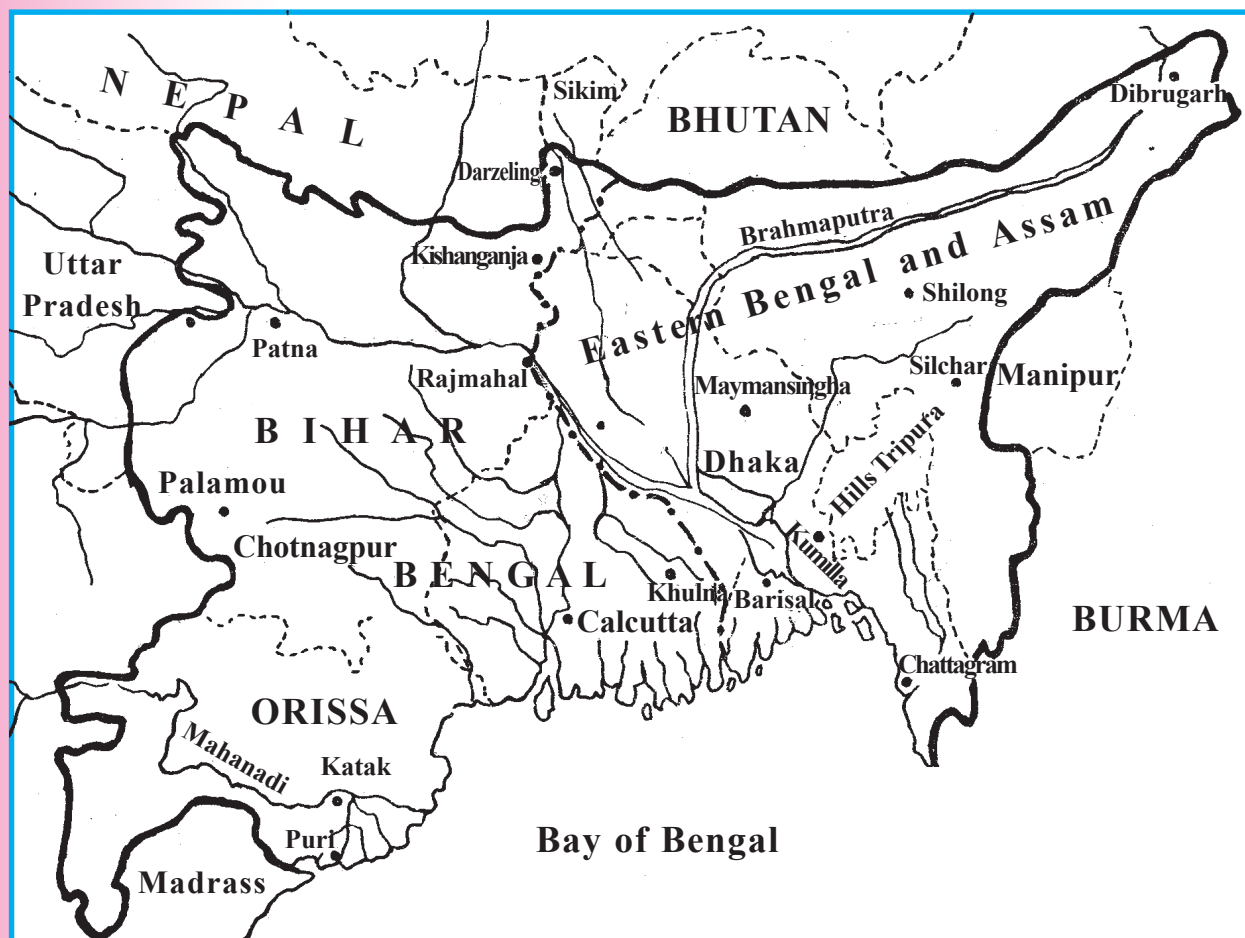
On 2nd February, 1905 Lord Curzon sent the proposal of partition of Bengal to Secretary of State for India in London for necessary approval. On 9th June, Secretary of State for India John Brodrick approved the proposal and informed the government of India by telegram message. On 19th July, 1905, the British government of India published this proposal. On 1st September, 1905, it was declared officially that the partition of Bengal would be implemented on 16th October. The four points programme on partition of Bengal declared by Lord Curzon on 1st September was as follows—

The 1st point (phase) of the partition of Bengal –

- (a) The name of the new province will be 'Eastern Bengal and Assam', by annexation of Rajshahi, Dhaka and Chittagong to Assam.
- (b) The capital of new province will be Dhaka.
- (c) The administration of Eastern Bengal and Assam will be handed over to a Lt. Governor.
- (d) The capital of Assam will be transferred from Shillong to Dhaka.

Partition of Bengal (1905-1911 A.D) and Swadeshi Movement

The boundary of divided Bengal as per the plan of Partition of Bengal of Lord Curzon.



2nd Point (Phase)

- (a) There will be separate high court in Dhaka for Eastern Bengal and Assam.
- (b) Until a separate high court is established, the new province will be under the jurisdiction of Calcutta high court.

3rd Point (Phase)

Calcutta will be the capital of New Bengal province which includes West Bengal, Bihar, Orissa and Chotanagpur.

4th Point (Phase)

The partition of Bengal will be implemented on 16th October, 1905.

1.03. Swadeshi Movement (1905 – 1911 A.D.)

The British government planned the partition of Bengal against the wishes of the people of Bengal. The leaders like Surendra Nath Banerjee, Bipin Chandra Paul, Arabinda Ghose, Rabindranath Tagore, Rasbihari Bose, Ramendra Sundar Trivedi etc. understood the conspiracy

of the British government and they were able to create awareness among the people against this conspiracy. They launched anti-partition propaganda among the people through various meetings and writings realising that the partition of Bengal would be a threat to the heritage of Bengalis and Hindu-Muslim unity as well. To create strong public opinion against the partition of Bengal, at first they started signature collecting campaign. The protest paper signed by 70,000 Indian was submitted to the Secretary of State for India. The British government remained strong and tried to justify Andrew Fraser's plan of partition of Bengal. But the people of Bengal broke out with anguish.

When it became clear that the government was adamant to implement this partition, the anti-government feeling rose gradually among the people of Bengal. Since the public opinion was disrespected, the whole Bengal broke out into national movement against this partition. Hindu-Muslim unity was put under threat and Bengali nationalism was wounded. Already there was dissatisfaction among the Indians as Lord Curzon interfered the rights of Indian on education, newspaper and local self government. His process of partition was also reactionary. Hence there was a huge public protest and dissatisfaction against this partition. From the partition proposal was raised on 6th December, 1903, till it was officially declared on 19th July, 1905, many places of East, West and North Bengal witnessed thousands of public protests and huge public uproars. Irrespective of caste, creed and religion people plunged into this movement. This movement became famous as Swadeshi movement because it was publicly recommended that the Indians would unitedly boycott foreign goods and would start using home-made goods made by the Indians.

Great sensation was created among the people by the article 'Bangar Sarbanash' published in the journal Sanjibani (6th July, 1904, editor Krishna Kumar Mitra). The first protest meeting against the proposed partition of Bengal was held at Khulna (Bagerbari) on 14th July, 1905. The prominent leaders like Surendranath Banerjee, Motilal Ghose, Dwizendralal Mitra etc. called the people for breaking this conspiracy of the British to divide the motherland. On 16th and 17th July, 1905, the same protest meeting was held at Kishorganj and Pabna respectively. The next day of the official declaration of the partition of Bengal, the 2nd protest meeting was held at Dinazpur on 20th July, 1905. This protest meeting was presided over by the king (Maharaja) of Dinazpur and the proposal was passed to boycott the British goods. Plan was taken to organize protest meeting at grass root level.

The student community was attracted to this environment of movement. The students of Ripon College (presently Surendra Nath College) for the first time staged a walk out from their classrooms and took part in the movement on 18th July, 1905. On 31st July, 1905, under the leadership of the students from Ripon College, a vast student rally was organised against this partition. They formed a central committee to launch various movements against this partition. On 7th August, 1905, a huge public meeting was held at Town Hall of Kasimbazar, Calcutta under the presidentship of Maharaja Manindra Chandra Nandi. At the call of the representatives from various places, a unanimous decision was passed to boycott the British goods. On that day the students recited the patriotic song of Mukunda Das, (Hey banga janani, Swarna prasabini...) by calling for boycotting foreign goods. A 'Student Union' was formed under the leadership of Surendranath Banerjee. Through his inspiring speech Rabindranath Tagore called the people for maintaining social harmony. To stop buying and selling of British goods, the students decided to continue picketing programme in the business institutions. The British goods were put on fire in the various protest rallies.

On 23rd September, 1905, a big protest rally was held at Rajabazar, North Calcutta. It was presided over by Abdul Rasul and prominent Muslim leader like Halim Gajnabi, Liakat Hussain, Md. Ismile Choudhury were present. This protest rally played an important role in continuing the movement against the partition of Bengal. On that day a historic foot March, a symbol of social harmony, took place where people of all caste, creed and religion took part in this procession.

On the day of implementation of the partition of Bengal *i.e.* 16th October, 1905, the people of Bengal observed 'National mourning day'. As per the proposal of Ramendra Sundar Trivedi every household in the Bengal province avoided cooking on that day. At the call of Rabindranath Tagore, the Bengali people of Calcutta observed Rakhibandhan on that day. People sang Tagore's Rakhi song, 'Bangalir pran, Bangalir Mon, Ek houk he Bhagaban.' To strengthen the unity and fraternity among Hindu and Muslims, they tied Rakhi at the hands of the pedestrians. Under the leadership of Rabindranath Tagore thousands of people gathered at Maszids at Kalutola and Chitpur and tied Rakhis to the Moulabi's and other Muslims. From that day it was decided that protest meeting would be organized in every district of Bengal and boycotting of the foreign goods would be done strictly. According to the instruction of student groups, all the students decided to go to school barefoot until the proposal for partition of Bengal would be cancelled.

On 16th October, 1905, a strike (Hartal) was held in the afternoon in entire Calcutta. All the shops, business establishments, educational and other institutions, buses and trams remained closed. Ananda Mohan Bose (President of Indian National Congress of Madras session, 1898) laid the foundation stone of 'Federal Hall' as symbol of unity and heritage of Bengal and he addressed a big public rally and called the people for joining the movement against the partition of Bengal. 'Vande Mataram' rent the air of Calcutta and patriotic slogans were roared every where. People of Bengal from that very day observed a year long mourning.

At the beginning, the swadeshi movement was confined to the boycotting of foreign goods and using indigenous goods. However, it was an economic pressure on the British. The intensity of the movement gradually increased and so the amount of boycotting foreign goods also became higher. Arbinda Ghose said, 'Boycotting means patriotism and the essence of patriotism is the non co-operation with the British in all respects.' This message from saint Arbinda made the feeling of patriotism more lively in the activists of this movement. People started avoiding British administration, govt. educational institutions, Courts etc. apart from foreign goods. Local goods were more appreciated by the people. People felt pride buying the things manufactured in India and by the Indians and this helped in building up the foundation of Indian economy. Indian people became united to boycott the foreign goods, which already occupied Indian markets. People developed a tendency not to pay their taxes, government loans etc. thinking the British government a foreign agency only.

Though the main centre of the Swadeshi movement was undivided Bengal, yet it crossed the boundaries of Bengal and soon took a form of a national movement. The people of Maharashtra, South India, North-East India supported this movement and it turned into an all Indian movement. Under the leadership of Surendranath Banerjee, Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Gopal Krishna Gokhale, Anundamohan Bose, Lala Lajpat Ray, Dadabhai Naoraji etc., this movement crossed the corridor of Bengal and spread to various states of the country.

The Swadeshi movement is considered as a full fledged successful movement. Every step of this movement inspired the people of Bengal and had a direct influence all over India. Through it was a political movement against the British, yet this seven years movement (1905-1911 A.D.) had a far reaching impact upon literature, society, education and economy of India.

1.04. Consequences of the Swadeshi Movement

(a) National Literature :

The tide of patriotism that emerged from the Swadeshi movement had contributed a lot to the national literature. On the influence of Swadeshi movement, many magazines, newspapers, books, dramas, songs and articles were published.

The 'Bengali' (1904) edited by Surendranath Banerjee, the 'Sanjibani' (1904) edited by Krishna Kumar Mitra, the 'Hitabaadi' (1905) by Kaliprasanna Kabya Bisharad and Yogendranath Vidyabhusan, the 'Yugantar' (Weekly, 1906) by Bhupendra Dutta, the 'Sandhya' (1906) by Brahmabandhab Upadhyaya, 'The Dawn' (1906) by Satish Chandra Mukherjee, the female magazine 'Su-Prabhat' (1906) by Kumudini Mishra, 'Vande Mataram' by Arabinda Ghose etc. created a strong national sentiment among the people and excelled the movement.

Some important plays written on the background of Swadeshi movement were- 'Palashir Prayachitta,' by Khirod Prasad, 'Sirajuddoula' and 'Mir Kasim' by Girish Ghose, 'Sabbas Bangali' by Amrit Lal Bose, 'Bangar Angashed' by Amarendranath Dutta etc. At the same time some famous books written on the background of Swadeshi movement were 'Japani Bir' by Swarna Kumari Devi, 'Joy Sangeet' by Pramathnath Ray Choudhury, 'Nabya Bharat' by Kartik Ch. Dasgupta, 'Bangalakhmir Bratakatha' by Ramendra Sundar Trivedi. Twenty three numbers of patriotic songs composed by Rabindranath Tagore on Swadeshi movement will remain a treasure of Indian Culture. The song 'Amar sonar Bangla Ami Tomake Bhal Basi' won the status of national enthem of independent Bangladesh. The song, 'jadi tor daak sune keu naa ase, tabe ekla cholo re...' received everlasting popularity. During the movement period, the songs of Rajanikanta Sen, Mukunda Das, Dwizendralal Roy etc. inspired the Bangalis. The article 'Bhai Bhai Ek Thai' written by Rabindranath Tagore on the background of Swadeshi movement was a famous article.

A national institution named 'Bangia Kala Sangsad' was established under the leadership of Abanindranath Thakur during the Swadeshi movement. This institution aimed at creating foundation of Indian Fine Arts, free from western influence. Through his famous painting 'Banga Mata' Abanindranath Thakur tried to establish Indian Fine arts at par with the western paintings. Sister Nibedita transformed 'Banga Mata' into 'Bharat Mata'.

(b) National Education :

The Swadeshi movement was not confined to boycotts of British goods

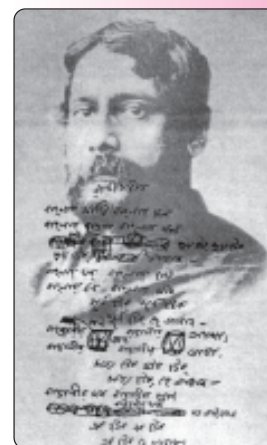
only. It also had a big influence on the prevalent educational system of Bengal. It was noticed that the movements were becoming popular among the students and the chief secretary of Bengal R.W. Carlyle circulated a notice (10th October, 1905) warning all the students not to take part in the movement. The student community made strong protest against this circular and they observed a walk out of the classroom. Under the presidentship of Rabindra Nath Tagore, a vast student rally was organized at Pataldanga Mallikbari (4th Nov. 1905) and on that rally, an 'Anti Circular Society' was formed to disobey the order of the government. This was the first incident of disobedience of government order.

The prominent leaders like Bipin Ch. Paul, Rabindranath Tagore, Abdul Rasul etc. called upon the student community to leave government institution. At the same time Satishchandra Mukherjee, the editor of 'the Dawn' named the University of Calcutta as the house of slaves (Golam-khana) and he called upon the students community to leave that house of slaves and to accept national education. Satish Ch. Mukherjee, started a national institution named 'Dawn Society', with full co-operation from Rabindra nath Tagore and Charu Das Banerjee and engaged in the work of spreading patriotic feeling among the students.

This society did against the Curzon's University law (1904) and Carlyle's circular (1905) and started movement for uprising the national education. On 5th August, 1905, Rabindranath Tagore gave a valuable lecture on importance of national education in a public meeting at Calcutta. Next day he established the Banga Jatiya Vidyalay where many people were present. On 8th November, 1905, the second Jatiya Vidyalay was established in Rangpur. The number of students leaving government schools increased and consequently many national schools were established at many places of Bengal. Under the leadership of Rasbihari Bose the National Education Council (Jatiya Siksha Parisad) was formed on 11th March 1906 at town hall Calcutta. Bengal National College was established on 15th August 1906. Arabinda Ghose was the first principal and in the same year on 12th December, Bengal National College was promoted to National University.

During the Swadeshi movement, all together 62 secondary schools and 3000 national primary schools were established. Bengal Technical Institute was established with the financial help from reputed barrister Taraknath Palit (a close friend of Anunda Ram Boruah, the first ICS of Assam.). Later on, this institution was changed into Jadavpur University. Bihar Vidyapeeth, Patna, Samarth Vidyalay, Maharastra and Gujrat Vidyalay, Gujrat were established in the style of National University.

Partition of Bengal (1905-1911 A.D) and Swadeshi Movement



Rabindranath Tagore



Rajanikanta Sen



**The famous picture
'Banga mata' by
Abanindranath Thakur**



Sister Nibedita, a source of inspiration of Swadeshi movement.

(c) The contribution of women in Swadeshi movement

Keeping equal pace with the man, the middle class urban women also took active part in the swadeshi movement by crossing all the social barriers. This participation of the women folk against the partition of Bengal led the Indian freedom struggle to a well organized level.

Among the prominent female leaders of swadeshi movement, Sarala Devi Choudhurini was to be reckoned to lead the Swadeshi movement in a revolutionary way. Like the Sivaji festival of Maharashtra, she started organizing various festivals like 'Birastami Brat' Pratapaditya Utshab, Udayaditya Utsav, Byayam Samitee etc. and trained the boys and girls on wrestling, stick play etc. games. She edited a magazine named 'Bharati' and prepared the youth force of Bengal to plunge into national movement.

Another prominent woman who contributed a lot in creating national awareness among the youths and the women was Sister Nibedita. This Ireland born strong lady had her real name as Margaret Elizabeth Noble (1864-1911). During her stay in Calcutta she was actively associated with Youngman's Hindu Union, Vivekananda Society, Dawn Society and Anusilan Sammitee and encouraged the youths and the women folk to be independent by involvement in indigenous industries.

The bravery of the Bengal women stunned the British Rulers. Regarding the courage of Bengal women, the Daily Telegraph, London on 11th October 1907 wrote – 'The Bengal women are the most obstinate and most dangerous antagonist of the English'.

(d) The rise of National Industry

On the background of swadeshi movement, the mentality for self development grew in Bengal and it brought a positive and congenial atmosphere for the establishment of national industries. As the demand of locally made goods grew higher, several big industries and various small scale industries came into being. Spinning machine, small and medium scale handloom industries, industries for producing mustard oil, soap, sugar, match box etc. and many biscuit factories were established. Along with this, national bank and national insurance companies came into existence. The Swadeshi Bhandar, established by Rabindranath Tagore became a reputed textile firm. At the prime time of Swadeshi movement Yogesh Ch. Choudhury and Krishna Bihari Sen jointly established, 'Indian stores' at Bou bazaar, Calcutta. All kinds of India made products were sold in this establishment. Another woman from Tagore's family named Sarala Devi

started, 'Lakshi Bhandar' at Cornwallis street (Now Bidhan Sarani). The 'United Bengal Stores' was established by Abdul Halim Gajnabi at Lal Bazar.

Some extra ordinary people like Jagadish Ch. Bose, Prafulla Ch. Roy, Nilratan Sarkar etc. planned to establish some heavy industries at Bengal to grow an atmosphere of self development and self reliance. At the initiative of Nilratan Sarkar, 'Banga Lakshi Cotton Mill' was established on 1st August, 1906 and Acharya Prafulla Ray started 'Bengal Chemicals' on 25th July, 1906. Jamshedji Tata established iron factory in 1907. As a consequence of boycotting foreign goods and productions of local industries, the number of imported goods came to be very low in India.

Due to the political movement in Bengal, the foundation of modern industries was laid in various provinces of India. The first Indian industrial summit was held on 17th December, 1905 under the chairmanship of R.C. Dutta at Varanashi and this summit awakened the Indians about the prospect of indigenous industries in India. Even revival of many national industries were possible after this summit. In short, the Swadeshi movement opened a new chapter in the progress of Indian industries and business.

(e) Establishment of Muslim League

The British government never wanted a vast and united India. To keep their imperialism intact, they tried to divide the Indians with respect to religion, language, caste and region. The partition of Bengal was also a big weapon to create communal feelings among Indians.

To build a strong public opinion in favour of the partition of Bengal, Lord Curzon took a programme of long trip in February, 1904. In the places like Dhaka, Maimonsing, Chattagram etc. he campaigned in favour of the partition of Bengal, saying that it would benefit the Muslim people a lot. On 18th Feb, 1904, he organized a big rally in Dhaka and called the Islamic people for standing unitedly against the Hindus. With the help of Nawab Sallimullah Khan, he tried to approach the Muslim of Bengal. For this purpose he lent Rs. 14 Lacs to Nawab with minimum interest. He also promised to give special facility to the Islam land Lords. Many Muslim leaders welcomed this partition of Bengal. The leaders who had belief in Lord Curzon, thought that this proposal of two states would be able to fulfil the aspirations of the Muslim community. They had also their vested interest and strong temptation for self establishment. In this way the British created a destructive political mentality in the Muslims.

Lord Minto became the Viceroy of India after Lord Curzon and his declaration on 13th April, 1906 indicated some special political gains to the Muslim citizens. He made an official declaration of Rules of Administrative Reform. After this declaration a section of Muslim leaders were united to discuss on how the interest of Muslims would be protected in the proposed reform rules. Discussing with William Archbold, the principal of Aligarh College, they prepared a petition. They demanded a separate electorate for the Muslims in the proposed reform. On 1st October, 1906 under the leadership of Aga Khan a representative group consisting of 35 members submitted the petition to Lord Minto at Simla. The Viceroy assured them that the demands would be considered. In such a favourable environment of royal grace, they deeply involved in bringing dream into reality.

On 30th December, 1906 some educated Muslim leaders attended a meeting at Dhaka palace. This meeting was organized by Nawab Salimullah and was presided by Nawab Bikor-Ul-Mulook. In this historic session a political organization named All India Muslim League was established. Nawab Salimullah, who led the creation of Muslim League declared the aims and objectives of this newly formed political organization on that day itself.

These were –

- (a) To increase the sense of loyalty of the Muslim people to British.
- (b) To keep aware the British government regarding the political rights and interests of the Muslim people.
- (c) To create the sense of unity among the Muslim people by removing feelings of being frightened, disgusted and terrorised.

Viceroy Lord Minto and Secretary of State for India Lord Morley expressed their satisfaction with the activities of the Muslim League. These two British officials took the opportunity of the differences of religion and opinion between Hindu and Muslim for political gain. Lord Minto also planned to bring the moderate groups of Congress close to British govt. within a very short period. The Muslim owned separate electorate through the Indian Council Act (Morley-Minto Reform), 1909.

The Muslim League emerged as an active political organization oponent to Indian National Congress to be able to represent the Indian Muslims. They could easily win the political rights by taking the opportunity of loyalty to the British. This league soon became a big force to weaken the Indian National Congress. In March 1910 the head office of Muslim League was transferred to Lukhnow.

The Muslim League could not influence every section of the society. It was confined to some high class conservative people and when the proposal for partition of Bengal was repealed in 1911, the importance of Muslim League declined. After the demise of Sallimullah in 1905 the conservative character of Muslim League went under the tremendous changes.



Bapuji, the initiator of Khadi

1.05 Swadeshi Movement and National Congress

Surendranath Banerjee, Bipin Ch. Paul, Arabinda Ghose, Aswini Kumar Dutta and many other intellectual leaders through the National Congress were able to unite people against partition of Bengal. During 1885-1905, National Congress mainly concentrated on social and economic development. But after the partition of Bengal, it could establish itself as a big organisation in the context of greater Indian nationalism.

The 19th annual session held in 1903 at Madras, under the presidentship of Lalmohan Ghosh, Indian National Congress warned the govt. to give up the plan of partition of Bengal. Before the implementation of partition of Bengal Lala Lajpat Ray and Gopal Krishna Gokhley reached London on 6th July, 1905 to give a representation on behalf of National Congress to give up the plan of partition of Bengal by the British government. They submitted a protest petition signed by the people of Bengal to the

Partition of Bengal (1905-1911 A.D) and Swadeshi Movement

Secretary of State for India against the implementation of partition. Since inspite of all the oppositions of the Indians the partition was implemented, the Indian National Congress, had to take strong stand against the partition.

After six years of Swadeshi Movement, the result of Bengal partition, the British government was compelled to go for unification of Bengal in 1911. This big incident brought about an opportunity to the people of India to be united for freedom and self government (Swaraj), the Indian National Congress being the central force of it.

1.06: Anti-Movement Actions of the Government

The British Government expected support from moderate group leaders of Congress on the issue of partition of Bengal. In order to keep these leaders loyal, Lord Curzon offered them various titles, posts, medals etc. The moderate Congress members were offered the post of judges in high court, member of British parliament, member in Viceroy's Council etc.



Lala Lajpat Ray, Bal Gangadhar Tilak and Bipin Chandra Paul
(Lal-Bal-Paul)

for obtaining support towards partition. In spite of all these policies, Curzon failed to control the anti-partition movement. The firm stand of Congress leaders like Surendranath Banerjee, Gopal Krishna Gokhale etc. against the partition of Bengal, set the government in to trap. Bipin Ch. Paul urged every leader to give up and return titles, posts and honours offered by the British government. The first response to this was Gopal Krishna Gokhale who returned the 'Knighthood' title to the British immediately.

1.07 The contribution of Swadeshi Movement :

- (1) The Swadeshi movement was able to give the Indians a political knowledge regarding mass movement. Indian people learnt that if the majority of the people come forward for a common cause, then a mass movement would certainly become successful.
- (2) The Indian National Congress from its inception believed in peaceful demand to the British govt. for the development of India. The partition

of Bengal brought a change in this outlook of the Congress. The Swadeshi movement made them realize that the progress of India is possible only through mass struggle.

- (3) Reigning over the post of Viceroy Lord Carzon declared, “administration and exploitation will go hand in hand”. This arrogance of the empirical ruler was retaliated through the determination of Indians to boycott foreign goods, the use of local goods and the starting of local industries. Therefore, the Swadeshi movement will always be remembered in the history of economic and industrial development of India.
- (4) The Indians got the privilege to demand for Swaraj through the Swadeshi movement. The sense of nationalism stirred by Swadeshi movement compelled the Indian National Congress for the first time to take the proposal for demanding Swaraj in its Calcutta session in 1906 under the presidentship of Dada Bhai Naoraji.
- (5) The Swadeshi movement also attracted the women of India to the mass movement. Two incidents played great role in this regard. Every family in the Bengal province went on fast on the day when Prafulla Chaki was executed. Every kitchen was closed down and all mothers passed the day by mourning. The second incident was the police torture on Bhupendra Nath Dutta, the editor of “Yugantar”, for his sharp criticism on the partition of Bengal. His mother Bhabaneswari Devi called the women for a mass movement instead of weeping for the incident. Thousands of women came out to join the movement.
- (6) The Swadeshi movement also gave birth to armed movement. The tendency to resort to violent method occurred in some section of activists.

The decision to repeal the partition of Bengal clearly showed the defeat and discontentment of the British Government. The success story of Swadeshi movement inspired the Indians to join and strengthen the national freedom struggle led by Mahatma Gandhi. The success of anti-partition movement will ever remain as an important event in the history of freedom struggle of India.

S U M M A R Y

- ☞ Partition of Bengal under the Viceroy Lord Curzon was an important event in the political history of India.
- ☞ The reason behind the partition, officially announced, was that the Bengal province was too large to be administered by a single Lieutenant Governor. A total area of 1,06,540 sq. mile comprised of Dhaka, Chhattagram and Rajshahi was annexed to Assam and came to be known as Eastern Bengal and Assam.
- ☞ Dhaka was established as the capital of Eastern Bengal and Assam.
- ☞ Lord Curzon suggested to limit the area of Bengal province for better administration. The main objective of this policy was to divide the unity of Bengal province.
- ☞ Through Partition of Bengal, Lord Curzon tried to break the centre of Indian nationalism. It resulted in division of Bengal into two parts and Hindu-Bengalis were turned into minorities in both the provinces.
- ☞ The decision to effect the partition of Bengal was announced in July 1905 by Lord Curzon the Viceroy of India. The partition took place on 16 Oct. 1905.
- ☞ Partition of Bengal created mass agitation among the people of Bengal.
- ☞ Following the partition, an anti-British movement broke out which involved non violent and violent protests and boycotts.
- ☞ Irrespective of caste, creed and religion, people got involved in the movement.
- ☞ Partition sparked an extremely major political crisis, which led to the beginning of Swadeshi movement that included boycotting of British goods and accepting Swadeshi goods.
- ☞ Although the centre of Swadeshi movement was undivided Bengal province, it spread out not only in Bengal but throughout India.
- ☞ Swadeshi movement was regarded as a successful and active movement. It had far reaching impact on literature, society, education, economy etc. of the country.
- ☞ In order to continue the British imperialism undisturbed, they tried to divide and rule Indians on the basis of castes, creeds, religions and regions.
- ☞ Another significant event during Swadeshi movement was the creation of Indian Muslim League, established by a section of Muslim elites in the direct instigation of the British.
- ☞ The emergence of violent movement is also an important event of the period of Swadeshi movement.
- ☞ The philosophy of INC changed after partition of Bengal. INC believed that the development of Indians would be possible only through mass movement.
- ☞ The capital of Assam was shifted from Shillong to Dhaka as a result of partition of Bengal.

- ☞ The effect of Swadeshi movement extended up to Assam also.
- ☞ Bengal was reunited on 12 December, 1911 as per the royal proclamation of Delhi. As a result of reunification-
 1. The capital of India shifted from Calcutta to Delhi.
 2. The administration of Assam came under the Chief Commissioner.
 3. The capital of Assam again shifted to Shillong.

E X E R C I S E

Very short answer questions :

1. In which Viceroy's time did the partition of Bengal take place?
2. On which date in 1905 did the partition of Bengal come into force?
3. In which meeting was the proposal of giving up foreign commodities accepted?
4. Who was the editor of the journal *Jugaantar* published in the time of Swadeshi movement?
5. When was the institution named National Education Council (Jatiya Siksha Parisad) established in Bengal?
6. Who was the main introducer of the industry named Bengal Chemicals?
7. Under whose presidentship did the Conference of Indian National Congress accept the proposal of *swaraj* for Indians?
8. When did the unification of Bengal take place?

Short/ long answer type questions :

1. Mention three main geographical regions of Bengal which were annexed to the province West Bengal and Assam created after the partition of Bengal.
2. Write briefly about what were the intentions of the partition of Bengal.
3. Why was the anti partition of Bengal movement named as Swadeshi movement? Discuss briefly.
4. Discuss the contributions of Swadeshi movement towards national education.
5. How did the national industries develop during Swadeshi movement? Explain in short.
6. What were the anti-movement measures taken by the British to dominate Swadeshi movement?
7. Mention three results of Swadeshi movement.
8. Mention three contributions of Swadeshi movement.

Write short notes on :

1. Kabiguru Rabindranath Tagore
2. Margaret Elizabeth Noble (Bhagini Nivedita)
3. Nawab Salimullah



CHAPTER-2

RISE OF GANDHI AND THE FREEDOM MOVEMENT OF INDIA

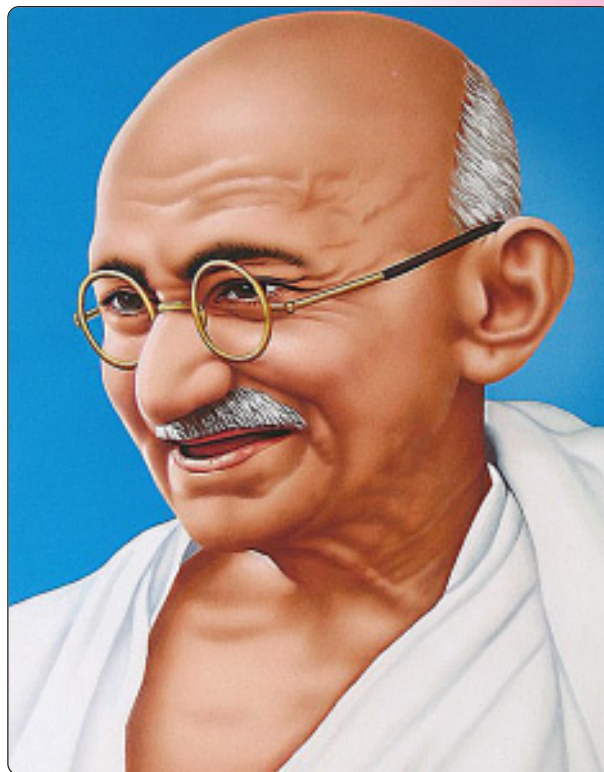
KEY POINTS

- Rise of Gandhi
- Non-Cooperation Movement
- Quit India Movement
- Indian Independence Act
- Non-violence Movement
- Civil Disobedience Movement
- Indian National Army

2.01 : Rise of Gandhi

The advent of Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, popularly known as Mahatma Gandhi was a landmark in the history of the freedom movement in India after the world war started in 1914. The Allied nations– Britain, U.S. and France promised that, democracy and national self determination would be offered to India after the war if they support for their war effort. Indian nationalists supported the war expecting this major political gain. But after the Allied victory in 1918, they showed little willingness to end colonial system. This attitude of British, gave rise to disillusion in the nationalists. International situation was also favourable to the resurgence of nationalism to which a major impetus was already given by the impact of the Russian Revolution of 1917. The Revolution brought home to the nationalist movement in India the fact that immense strength and energy reside in the common people.

The Russian Revolution enormously influenced the freedom lover people of India to come forward. The stage was set for Gandhi's entry into the national movement who had already established himself with his leadership in South Africa and in Champaran (North Bihar), Ahmedabad, Kheda (Gujrat) in India. He not only energized the national movement by resurrecting the ideology of truthfulness and non-violence, but also compelled the British to leave the country. Before he took leadership in Indian national movement, Gandhi began the struggle of Indians against racism in South Africa in 1893, when he was a twenty four year old barrister only.



Mahatma Gandhi was born at Porbandar in Gujarat on October 2, 1869 in a well-to-do family. He proceeded to England in 1888 to study law, and returned to India as a Barrister-at-law in 1891. After a brief stint as a lawyer both in Rajkot and Bombay, he went to Natal, South Africa in 1893 in connection with professional work. He was deeply shocked by the political and social discriminations which were imposed by the Europeans upon Indian residents. Being humiliated on more than one occasion, he soon assumed leadership of the struggle of Indians against racial discrimination in South Africa. He founded a political association known as Natal Indian Congress and also a newspaper called *Indian Opinion* with a view to educating Indians in political matters and give publicity to their grievances. It was during this struggle that he used for the first time the weapon of non-violent resistance later known as *Satyagraha* against a humiliating law. The same strategy was adopted against another law which prevented Indians from entering into the Transvaal province. *Satyagraha* was also offered against a judicial decision which made illegal all Indian marriages in South Africa which were not registered and performed in accordance with Christian rites. Gandhi was arrested and imprisoned for nine months but later the Government had to compromise in the form of Indian Relief Act and Gandhi was released.

The word *Satyagraha* was first used by Gandhi in South Africa. It is a compound of two separate words, *Satya* (truth) and *agraha* (adherence, holding fast). Its root meaning is 'holding on to truth'.

Gandhi explained that *Satyagraha* was not mere passive resistance. It meant intense political activity by large masses of people. Non-violence formed the very basis of *Satyagraha*. In evolving the concept of *Satyagraha*, Gandhi was influenced by the writings of Tolstoy and Thoreau.

Gandhi's activities in South Africa transformed him into a mature and idealist leader. With this impression he returned to India in 1915. He had to be actively involved and became successful in solving three local disputes— in Champaran (North Bihar), in Kheda (Gujarat) and in Ahmedabad during 1917-18, which recognised him as an influential political leader.

In Champaran, he took up the cause of peasants against landlords, in Kheda that of farmers against the collection of land-revenue when their crops failed, and in Ahmedabad that of the mill-workers against the mill owners. In each of the cases, the strategy was *Satyagraha*, and the principles were truth and non-violence. And in every case the real force working under Gandhi was 'mass participation'.

When the First World War broke out in 1914, the Indians rendered valuable service to the British. The Congress gave ample demonstration of loyalty. Mahatma Gandhi showed great enthusiasm and urged the Gujarat peasants to join the army if they want to win *Swaraj* or self-rule. Until 1918, he was a supporter of the British government.

The expectations of Indian nationalists for major political gains after the Great War of 1914-1918 remained unfulfilled. The post war years were marked by severe economic hardships. Indian industries faced losses and closure. The workers faced unemployment, high prices and poverty; the peasantry was groaning under deepening poverty and high taxation; and the urban educated Indians faced increasing unemployment. Almost all sections of Indian society were adversely affected. Events of the year 1919 also disillusioned Gandhi and from a cooperator of the British, he turned to a non-cooperator.

2.02 : Rowlatt Act, 1919

In 1917, the Governor General Lord Chelmsford appointed a Committee under the Chairmanship of Justice Sydney Rowlatt to investigate the nature and extent of revolutionary activities, and to suggest legislation if necessary to deal with them effectively. On the basis of its Report, the government passed the Rowlatt Act in 1919. The Act authorized the government to imprison any person without trial and conviction in a Court of law. The Act came as a rude shock to Indians.

2.03 : *Satyagraha* or Non-violence movement, 1919

In protest against the Rowlatt Act, Gandhi started the *Satyagraha* or the Non-Violence movement in 1919. *Satyagraha* according to Gandhi, was a 'religious movement', a process of purification and penance'. The movement was launched on April 6, 1919, with a day of *hartal* when business was to be suspended and the people were to fast and pray. The movement gradually became a mass movement. It projected Gandhi as 'an all India leader with immense potential'. He was arrested but was soon set free. The government on its part crushed the movement with a heavy hand.

2.04 : The Jallianwala Bagh Massacre, April 13, 1919

Within a week of the *hartal* of April 6, a considerable part of Punjab was convulsed with agitation. On April 10, Dr. Satyapal and Dr. Kitchlew, two popular leaders of the province, were arrested and deported from Amritsar. On April 13, a public meeting was held in Jallianwala Bagh in Amritsar. General Dyer, who was in command of the troops, took no steps to prevent it from being held. The meeting ground was enclosed on all sides by high walls and had one narrow entrance. Under the orders of General Dyer, British troops mercilessly fired on the unarmed and defenseless people. Hundreds of lives were

lost and many more were wounded. Martial law was proclaimed in Punjab. It was marked by indiscriminate arrests, confiscation of property, whipping etc. The government appointed a Committee of Enquiry under Lord Hunter to probe the Punjab disturbances. Dyer was removed from active service by the British government

in London, but he was absolved from guilt. A strong wave of discontent swept the country. Rabindranath Tagore renounced his Knighthood in protest against the Jallianwala Bagh Massacre.



A picture of Jallianwala Bagh Massacre

2.05 : Khilafat Movement

As a result of the defeat of Turkey in the First World War, the influence of the Khalifa was greatly reduced. The Muslims regarded the Sultan of Turkey as their Khalifa or spiritual head. They became upset when they found that he would retain no control over his empire's holy places. The Muslims in India became apprehensive of the fate of the Khalifa and formed a Khilafat Committee under the leadership of Maulana Shaukat Ali and Mohammad Ali. Its object was the restoration of the Sultan of Turkey as Khalifa (Caliph) of Islam. Gandhi decided to extend support to the Khilafat Movement as he viewed it as a golden opportunity for bringing Muslims and Hindus together on the national front. He successfully persuaded the Khilafat Committee to accept the non-violent non-cooperation movement as the only effective way to force the government to accept its demand.

2.06 : The Non-Cooperation Movement, 1920-22

The Non-cooperation Movement (Asahayog Andolan) was a major event in the Indian struggle for independence. This movement started in 1920 and lasted through 1922, supported all along by the Indian National Congress. Under Mahatma Gandhi's leadership, the movement aimed at British rule through non-violence (ahimsa). Activists refused to buy British goods, used only local handicrafts, and picketed liquor shops. The goal was to uphold Indian honour and integrity in a peaceful manner. Thousands of common citizens rallied for the cause and it was the first large scale movement in the history of India's independence. Many factors culminated over time leading to the Non-cooperation movement. Some of the significant causes were

1. The discontent over the World War-I, as it had taken big toll on India's economy and human resource.
2. The growing British oppression of Indians as demonstrated by the Rowlatt Act of 1919. It provided the authority with the right to imprison any person suspected of terrorism for two years without any trial. Under Gandhi a wide spread protest movement took place against the Act.
3. The Jalianwala Bagh massacre of 1919.
4. The economic exploitation of India by the British.
5. The Indian Muslims had launched the Khilafat movement to ensure protection of the Ottoman Empire.

The realisation by the national leaders that the constitutional reforms were not sufficient enough to provide equitable justice to

Indians and thus decided to launch the Non-cooperation movement under the leadership of Gandhi at a special session of Indian National Congress held at Calcutta in 1920. The movement seriously challenged the economic and political power of the British.

The Non-Cooperation Movement ignited the emotions of the people. Both Hindus and Muslim participated in it. There was huge bonfire of foreign cloth in different places. Shops selling foreign goods and liquor were picketed. Many students left government schools and colleges. The peasants of Midnapore in Bengal organized a very effective no-tax campaign. The Congress set up National educational institutions like the Kashi Vidyapeeth, Banaras Vidyapeeth, the National Muslim University of Aligarh etc. Seth Jamona Lal Bajaj declared that he would give Rupees one lakh a year for the maintenance of non-practising lawyers. Forty lakh volunteers were enrolled by the Congress. Twenty thousand '*Charkhas*' were manufactured. The people started deciding their disputes by means of arbitration. The Tilak Swarajya Fund which was started to finance the Non-cooperation movement was able to collect over a crore of rupees within a short period. The women too actively took part in the movement. Even the visit of the Prince of Wales was boycotted. Gandhi toured almost the whole country to whip up enthusiasm of the people.

The Non-cooperation movement had two aspects – positive and negative. The former included the promotion of *Swadeshi*, particularly the revival of hand-spinning and weaving; removal of untouchability among the Hindus; promotion of Hindu-Muslim unity; prohibition of the use of alcoholic drinks, and the collection of a crore of rupees for the memorial of Tilak (in terms of *Swarjya* Fund).

The negative side is usually referred to as the triple boycott; namely, boycott of Legislatures, Courts and educational institutions- schools and colleges maintained or aided by the Government. The minor items of boycott included surrender of titles, honours etc. The negative programme necessitated some positive steps, like setting up- arbitration boards to take the place of Courts, and National schools and colleges where students leaving Government schools and colleges might continue their education. It was made clear that *Ahimsa* or Non-violence was to be strictly observed by the non-cooperators. They were not to give up *satya* or truth under any circumstances.

The movement launched by Gandhi was ratified by the Nagpur session of the Congress in December, 1920. It declared that 'the object of the Indian National Congress is the attainment of *Swaraj* by the people of India by all legitimate and peaceful means'. A new era dawned

upon India's struggle for freedom. The Congress for the first time decided to follow a policy of direct action. The Congress became a mass-based organization.

2.07 : End of Non-Cooperation Movement, 1922

Much against the wishes and instructions of Gandhi, people at certain places did not remain peaceful. On February 5, 1922, there was serious mob violence at Chauri Chaura in Gorakhpur district of United Province (British India). The local police attacked the protestors and then they violently collided with the police. Three protestors were killed in police firing. Protestors burnt down the police station and about twenty two policemen were killed. Gandhi was shocked at this incident and felt that without adequate discipline and restraint on the part of the people, the Movement had proved to be a 'Himalayan blunder'. He at once suspended the movement and sat on fast for three weeks. Many congress leaders welcomed the decision of Gandhi, but at the same time some other national leaders did not like to stop the movement for isolated incidents of violence. He was arrested on 10th March, 1922 and sentenced to six years imprisonment for the allegation that he instigated people for violence. Still Gandhi remained firm on his principle of non-violence. His imprisonment again led to another movement. The Congress Working Committee ratified Gandhi's decision and accordingly on February 12, 1922, the Non-cooperation movement came to an end.

2.08 : Simon Commission

The Government of India Act of 1919, laid down that after a period of about ten years, a Commission would arrive in India to inquire into the working of the reforms introduced by it. Accordingly, in 1928, a Commission of seven members under the leadership of Sir John Simon reached India. But as the Commission did not have a single Indian member, the Congress boycotted it. Slogans of 'Go Back Simon' rent the air. At Lahore, a procession organized against the Simon Commission under the leadership of Lala Lajpat Rai was 'lathi-charged'.



Protest rally against Simon Commission

Lajpat Rai was seriously wounded and he subsequently died.

Demand for Complete Independence or Purna Swaraj : In 1929, the Lahore session of the Congress under the Presidentship of Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru declared Complete Independence as the chief goal of the Indians. Consequently, **January 26, 1930, was celebrated as Independence Day throughout the country.**

2.09 : Civil Disobedience Movement, 1930-34

One of the factors leading to the Civil Disobedience Movement was the formation of the Simon Commission by the British Government. It included only the British Parliament members and came into effect in November 1927 to report the working of the constitution established by the Government of India Act of 1919. However, political parties and social organisations of India did not accept the Commission as it was accused of being an 'All-White Commission'. This was followed by a strike in Bengal on 3 February 1928. Simon's arrival in Calcutta was met with demonstrations. Meanwhile, Motilal Nehru shouldered the responsibility of the drafting committee and prepared the constitution for India. Indian National Congress accepted the Nehru Report and pressurised the government to accept it. The Calcutta Session of the INC held in 1928 warned the British government that it would start a Civil Disobedience Movement if India was not granted the dominion status.

In 1929, at Lahore Congress, it was decided that the goal of the Congress was to attain Purna Swaraj or complete independence for India. Consequently, on 26 January 1930, 'Purna Swaraj Day' was celebrated in India. On 31 January 1930, Gandhi gave an ultimatum to the Viceroy Lord Irwin to remove the evils of the British rule with a list of demands. The list of demands was:

- Prohibition of use of intoxicants,
- Change of the ratio of rupee and sterling
- Reduction of the rate of land revenue
- Abolition of salt tax
- Reduction of military expenditure
- Reduction of expenditure on civil administration
- Imposition of custom duty on foreign cloths
- Acceptance of the Postal Reservation Bill
- Abolition of the Crime Investigation Department.
- Release of all political prisoners
- Issuing license of arms to citizens for self protection, subject to popular control

Gandhi clearly mentioned that if those 11 points were ignored, then the nation would be going to launch the Civil Disobedience movement. Consequently, the Civil Disobedience Movement started in 1930 with the famous Salt Satyagraha of Gandhi, also known as Dandi March that was launched on 12 March 1930. On that



The famous Dandi march of Gandhi

day, Gandhi with some of his followers left the Sabarmati Ashram at Ahmedabad and made their way towards Dandi, a village on the west coast of India. After travelling for twenty-five days and covering a distance of 385 km, they reached Dandi on 6 April 1930. Here, Gandhi protested against the Salt Law (salt was a monopoly of the government and no one was allowed to make salt) by making salt himself and throwing up a challenge to the British government.

The movement spread and salt laws were challenged in other parts of the country.

In the North West Frontier Province, the Movement was led by the 'Khudai Khitmadgars' (Servants of God) popularly known as the Red Shirts under the leadership of Khan Abdul Gaffar Khan (also known as 'Frontier Gandhi'). Gandhi and thousands of freedom lovers (men, women and children) were arrested. The first Round Table Conference in London was boycotted by the Congress as the Civil Disobedience Movement was going on.

2.10 : Gandhi – Irwin Pact, 1931

On March 5, 1931, an agreement of understanding was reached between Mahatma Gandhi and Lord Irwin, Viceroy of India. The terms of the agreement included the immediate release of all political prisoners not convicted for violence, the remission of all fines not yet collected and the return of confiscated lands of *Satyagrahis* not yet sold to third parties. The government also conceded the right to make salt for consumption to villages along the coast, as also the right to peaceful and non-aggressive picketing. The Congress on its part agreed to suspend the Civil Disobedience movement. It was also understood that the Congress would participate in the next Round Table Conference.

2.11 : The Second Round Table Conference, 1931

The Second Round Table Conference was held in London in 1931. Mahatma Gandhi participated in it as the sole representative of the Congress. The conference was a failure as no decisions could be reached regarding joint or separate electorates and the number of seats for various communities. Gandhi returned to India being disappointed.



A picture of the Second Round Table Conference

2.12 : Restarting of the Civil Disobedience Movement, 1932

The Civil Disobedience Movement was re-started in 1932, but even before the movement actually started Gandhi was arrested along with Vallabhbhai Patel who at that time was the President of the Congress. The government also took forcible possession of the office of the Congress. Lathi-charges were common to disperse the crowds. Even women and children were not spared. Whipping became a common punishment. The freedom of the Press was curtailed. Nationalist literature - poems, stories and novels were banned on a large scale. Yet, the movement continued to linger on. However, a stage came when the political enthusiasm of the people became less and less and feelings of frustration set in. The Movement was suspended in May, 1933 and completely withdrawn in May, 1934.

The Civil Disobedience Movement demonstrated the awakening of the political consciousness among the Indian masses. At the same time, it exposed the British rule in India in all its naked hideousness and lowered its prestige in the eyes of the world.

2.13 : Communal Award, 1932

It was during the disturbed days of the Civil Disobedience Movement that the British policy of 'Divide and Rule' found a new expression in the announcement of the Communal Award in August, 1932, by British Prime Minister Ramsay Macdonald. Apart from continuing with the policy of giving separate electorates to the minority communities, namely, Sikh, Christian and Muslim, the Award declared the depressed classes also to be minorities. They were given separate electorates and thus separated them from the rest of the Hindus. On this issue, **Gandhi, then in Jail, undertook a fast unto death.** He

succeeded in getting the Poona Pact (1932) by which the depressed classes along with other Hindus were to have joint electorates. The British government agreed to amend the Communal Award in the light of the Poona Pact. Gandhi soon got fully involved in the anti-untouchability struggle, which led to the foundation of the **Harijan Sevak Sangh**.

2.14 : Formation of Congress Ministries, 1937-1939

In 1935, the British government passed the Government of India Act by which Provincial autonomy was given to the Indian Provinces. As a result of the elections, the Congress party formed government in eight out of the eleven provinces, with the exception of Punjab, Sind and Bengal. The prestige of the Congress as the alternative to colonial state rose even higher.

2.15 : Resignation of Congress Ministries, 1939

When the Second World War broke out, the Government of India immediately declared India to be at war with Germany without consulting the Congress or the elected members of the Central legislature. The Congress claimed that since the war had been declared without the consent of the Indian people, it could not associate itself with it unless India was declared an independent nation. The Congress ministries therefore resigned on November 1, 1939.

2.16 : Demand for Pakistan, 1940

The resignation of the Congress ministries was celebrated by the Muslim League as ‘The Day of Deliverance’ on December 22, 1939. At the Lahore session of the Muslim League (March, 1940), Jinnah, in his Presidential Address, emphasizing on his Two-nation theory demanded a separate homeland for the Muslims or what he called as Pakistan. The English who wanted to weaken the national movement also encouraged separatist spirit.

2.17 : Individual *Satyagraha*, Oct, 1940

In August, 1940, the Viceroy announced the famous ‘August offer’ proposing the expansion of the Viceroy’s Executive Council, and to constitute it as a War Advisory Council for the purpose of associating Indians in war efforts. However, as it did not propose the granting of independence, the offer was rejected both by the Congress and Muslim League. As a moral protest against Britain’s policy towards India, the Congress started the Individual *Satyagraha* in October, 1940, under the guidance of Mahatma Gandhi. Individual *Satyagraha* was also known as ‘*Delhi Chalo*

Satyagraha'. The first *satyagrahi* to court arrest was Acharya Vinoba Bhave.

2.18 : Cripps Mission, 1942

The entry of Japan in the War and their remarkable success posed a real danger to the safety of India's defence. It made England to soften her attitude towards India. In March 1942, the British War Cabinet sent Sir Stafford Cripps with new constitutional proposals. He proposed to set up an Indian Union with Dominion status soon after the war. He had consultations with the different political parties, but as he did not propose any immediate transfer of power, his scheme was not accepted both by the Congress and the Muslim League. The general feeling was expressed by a pithy saying, that they were a 'post-dated cheque on a crashing bank'.

2.19 : Quit India Movement, August 1942

In September 1939, the Second World War broke out. M.K. Gandhi and J. Nehru both were strongly critical of Hitler and the Nazis. Therefore, they promised the British to provide the support of the Congress to their war efforts, in return they asked to grant India complete independence. The offer was not accepted by the British government. As a mark of protest the Congress ministers resigned in October 1939. Between 1940 and 1941, the Congress organised a series of individual satyagrahas to put pressure on the government. At this time Britain had all party government, whose labour members were sympathetic to the demands of the Indians, but the Prime Minister Winston Churchill was conservative enough to liquidate Britain's empire. In 1942, Churchill was pressurised to send one of his ministers, Sir Stafford Cripps to negotiate with Indian political parties seeking their support in the war that Britain was waging in Europe. A Draft Declaration of the British Government was offered to India, which included the establishment of a dominion, the establishment of a constituent assembly and the rights of provinces to make separate constitutions. All this would be granted only after the war. However, the Cripps mission failed and Gandhi decided to launch his third major movement against the British. Other factors which led to the Quit India Movement was the fear of Japan attacking India, terror in East Bengal and the fact that India had realised that the British could not defend the country anymore.

Accordingly, in August 1942, Gandhi launched the Quit India Movement, also known as the August Movement on the basis of the resolution passed on 8 August, 1942 in Bombay by the All India



8 August 1942, Gandhi's speech in Quit India Movement

Congress Committee, declaring its demand for an immediate end of the British rule. The nation was inspired by the Gandhi's slogan of 'Do or Die' ('Karo ya Maro').

Immediately, the Congress was banned and Gandhi and most of the Congress leaders were swiftly arrested; most of whom had to spend the next three years in jail, until World War II ended. The people, however, were unstoppable. There were hartals and demonstrations all over the country. The people attacked all symbols of the British govern-

ment such as railway stations, law courts and police stations. Railway lines were damaged and telegraph lines were cut. In some places, people even set up their independent government. The movement was most widespread in Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Bengal, Bombay, Odisha and Andhra Pradesh. Places such as Ballia, Tamluk, Satara, Dharwar, Balasore and Talcher were freed from British rule and the people there formed their own governments.



Protest procession in Quit India Movement

Though the movement was short-lived, it demonstrated the depth that nationalist feeling had reached in the country and the great capacity for struggle and sacrifice that the people had developed. The movement marked a new high in terms of participation of the masses in the nationalist struggle for freedom. Students, women, peasants and workers played important roles. This historic movement placed the demand for independence in the immediate

agenda of the national movement. After 'Quit India' there could be no retreat. Independence was no longer a matter of bargain, for any future negotiations with the British government could only be on the manner of transfer of power.

2.20 : Indian National Army

After the suppression of the Revolt of 1942, there was hardly any political activity inside the country till the war ended in 1945. The national movement however found a new expression outside the country's frontiers. In 1941, Subhas Chandra Bose, who was twice elected as President of the Indian National Congress, was interned in his own house in Calcutta for his anti-British activities. But he eluded police vigilance and went to Afghanistan, Russia, Germany and ultimately to Burma and Malaya. In 1943, with the aid of expatriate nationalist leader Rash Behari Bose, the Indian National Army (INA) or the Azad Hind Fauz was revived.



Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose

The idea of the Indian National Army (INA) was first conceived by Captain Mohan Singh, an Indian officer of the British army in Malaya who had to surrender to the Japanese in the Second World War.

In March, 1942, a conference of expatriate Indians was held in Tokyo which led to the formation of the **Indian Independence League**. This was followed by a conference in Bangkok (June, 1942) where Rash Behari Bose was elected President of the League and a decision was taken to raise the Indian National Army or Azad Hind Fauz. The Bangkok conference also invited Subhas Chandra Bose to Japan. Shortly after his arrival, Rash Behari Bose resigned from the Presidency of the Indian Independence League in favour of Bose.

In Singapore, on October 21, 1943, he formed the 'Provisional Government of free India' (Azad Hind Sarkar) whose object was to expel the British from Indian soil. The INA was reorganized, and apart from the Indian Prisoners of War, recruits were sought from civilians, funds were gathered and even a women's regiment called the Rani Jhansi regiment was formed.

The slogan of the INA was 'Jai Hind'. It fought with the Japanese army against the British and Commonwealth forces in the campaigns in Burma, Imphal and Kohima. Bose's famous quote, 'give me blood

and I shall give you freedom' motivated his followers. However, the defeat of Japan and surrender in the war also led to the eventual surrender of INA.

Subhas Bose is reported to have been killed in an air crash in August, 1945. Even though his strategy of winning freedom in cooperation with the Fascist powers was criticized, at the same time most of the Indian nationalist praised him for organizing the INA to set an inspiring example of patriotism before the Indian people and the Indian army. He was hailed as Netaji by the entire country.

TOWARDS INDEPENDENCE : In 1945, the Second World War concluded in favour of the English. So with a view to giving some more powers to the Indians, Lord Wavell, the Viceroy of India, called a conference of the different political leaders at Simla. The conference failed and the political deadlock continued.

In 1946, the new Labour party Prime Minister, Mr. Clement Attlee, who was sympathetic to the Indians, sent the **Cabinet Mission to India**. Its aim was to resolve the deadlock and make India a free country. The Mission comprised of three members of Attlee's Cabinet, viz, Sir Stafford Cripps, Lord Pathic Lawrence and Mr. A.V. Alexander. Among other things, the Mission recommended that (i) there was to be a Union of India comprising both British India and the Indian states with control over foreign affairs, defence and communication. India was to be divided into three groups of provinces- Group A consisting of Madras, Bombay, Central Provinces, United Provinces, Bihar and Orissa; Group B - North West Frontier Province, Punjab, Sind and Baluchistan; and Group C- Bengal and Assam. (ii) A Constituent Assembly should be elected to draw the future Constitution of the country (iii) Till the Constitution was ready, an interim government should be set up at the Centre.

In the elections for the Constituent Assembly, the Congress bagged majority seats. The Muslim League boycotted the Assembly and on August 16, 1946, it observed the 'Direct Action Day' to achieve Pakistan. Communal riots broke out in different parts of the country, especially Bengal. Nevertheless, an interim government under the leadership of Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru was formed at the centre. The Muslim League initially refused to be a part of the ministry, but later joined it of its own accord. The rift between the Congress and the Muslim League however continued.

On February 20, 1947, Prime Minister Attlee announced the decision of His Majesty's Government to hand over power to the people

of India by a date not later than June, 1948. In March 1947, Lord Mountbatten replaced Lord Wavell as the Viceroy of India.

2.21 : Declaration of June 3, 1947

On June 3, 1947, Lord Mountbatten declared that the only solution to the political impasse was the partition of the country, and he won over the Congress leaders to that viewpoint. The main features of his declaration were - (i) India was to be partitioned. (ii) A referendum would be held in North West Frontier Province to ascertain whether their inhabitants wanted to join India or Pakistan. (iii) The Provincial Legislatures of Punjab and Bengal would decide whether these provinces were to be partitioned or not and (iv) The native states were free to join either India or Pakistan.

2.22 : Indian Independence Act, 1947

The British Parliament passed the Indian Independence Act in July 1947. Its main provisions were-

- (i) India and Pakistan were to become independent on August 15, 1947.
- (ii) Two dominions of India and Pakistan were to be established and their Constituent Assemblies were to decide whether to remain within the British Commonwealth of Nations or not.
- (iii) Each dominion was to have a Governor General appointed by the King.
- (iv) The Legislatures of both the dominions were fully empowered to make their laws.



2.23 : August 15, 1947, birth of Independent India

On August 15, 1947, British domination over India came to an end. The country was partitioned into India and Pakistan. Mohammad Ali Jinnah became the first Governor General of Pakistan, while Lord Mountbatten was appointed as the first Governor-General of Free India. Jawaharlal Nehru was sworn in as the Prime Minister.

On August 17, 1947, the Radcliffe Line was accepted as the boundary demarcation line between India and Pakistan. In March 1971, when Bangladesh (formerly East Pakistan) became Independent from Pakistan, the Radcliffe Line remained as the demarcation line between India and Bangladesh.



**Pandit Jawaharlal
Nehru**

S U M M A R Y

MAHATMA GANDHI : CHRONOLOGICAL PROFILE

- 1869 : Born at Porbander (Gujarat) on 2 October.
Father : Karam Chand Gandhi.
Mother : Putlibai Gandhi.
- 1881 : Married to Kasturba.
- 1888 : Went to England to study law.
- 1893 : Went to South Africa to represent a firm of Porbander Muslims in Natal as a lawyer.
- 1893-1914 : Campaigns in South Africa to defend the rights of Indian immigrants.
- 1914 : Awarded 'Kaiser-i-Hind' Gold Medal for his services in the Boer War II.
- 1915 : Returned to India. Establishes *Ashram* at Sabarmati.
- 1919 : Launches anti-Rowlatt Act agitation. Jallianwalabagh massacre on 13 April. Gandhi returns the Kaiser-i-Hind Gold Medal.
- 1920 : Non-cooperation movement was started.
- 1922 : Withdraws the movement after Chauri-Chaura incident.
- 1922-27 : Was away from active politics, but worked for
 - (a) Removal of untouchability
 - (b) Hindu-Muslim unity;
 - (c) and Popularising Khadi.
- 1928 : Bardoli *Satyagraha*.
- 1929 : I.N.C authorizes him to launch the Civil disobedience movement.
- 1930 : Dandi march (from 12 March to 6 April)
- 1931 : Gandhi-Irwin pact. Participated in the Second Round Table conference.
- 1932 : Gandhi started 'fast unto death'(20 September) against Communal Award. The Poona Pact (25 September).
- 1933 : Started the publication of a weekly '*Harijan*'.
- 1934-38 : Was away from active politics. Settled at Sevagram (Wardha).
- 1939 : Resumes active politics.
- 1940 : Resumes Congress leadership for a brief period.
- 1942 : Adopted 'Quit India' resolution, gave the slogan 'Do or Die'.
- 1944 : Lost his wife Kasturba while in detention at Aga Khan Palace.
- 1948 : Assassinated by Nathu Ram Godse (30 January).

EXERCISE

Very short/ short answer questions :

1. When was Mahatma Gandhi born?
2. In which country did Gandhi first apply the technique of *Satyagraha*?
3. Why did Rabindranath Tagore renounce his Knighthood?
4. Under whose leadership was the Khilafat movement started in India?
5. When did the Chauri-Chaura incident take place?
6. Under what circumstances did Lala Lajpat Rai lose his life?
7. When and in which session of the Indian National Congress was *Purna Swaraj* declared to be the chief goal of the Indians?
8. Gandhi started on his Salt march from Sabarmati Ashram to the sea coast at Dandi. What was the distance between Sabarmati Ashram and the sea –coast at Dandi?
9. Who was known as Frontier Gandhi?
10. Who was the sole Congress representative at the Second Round Table Conference in London?
11. Name the British Prime Minister who announced the Communal Award in 1932?
12. During the course of which movement did Gandhi give the slogan “Do or Die”?
13. Who was the founder of the Azad Hind Fauz?
14. “Give me blood and I shall give you freedom”. This famous quote is attributed to which Indian leader?
15. What is the name of the International Boundary Line between India and Pakistan?

Long Answers :

1. What do you understand by the term *Satyagraha*? Briefly write about the three local disputes where Gandhi first applied the technique of *Satyagraha* in India?
2. Why was the Khilafat movement started in India?
3. Why did Mahatma Gandhi launch the Non cooperation movement of 1920-22? What were its programmes? What made Gandhi suspend the movement?
4. What was the main aim of the Civil Disobedience Movement? What were the main features of the movement?
5. Under what circumstances was the Quit India movement launched? Do you consider the movement to be a milestone in India’s struggle for independence? Give reasons in support of your answer.
6. Write a brief note on the Indian National Army.



Chapter-3

ANTI-BRITISH RISING AND PEASANT REVOLTS IN ASSAM

KEY POINTS

- Anti-British uprising in Assam
- Revolt of 1857 in India and its impact in Assam.
- Rebellion of Maniram Dewan.
- Causes of the failure of his rebellion.
- Impact of the Revenue administration of the British in Assam.
- *Raijmel* and peasant revolts in various places.
- Tribal Revolts.

3.0 : Anti-British uprising in Assam

By the thirties and forties of the 19th century the East India Company established itself as a powerful ruler in India. In Assam also, they created a strong administrative base and successfully thwarted all possible uprisings of the local people against the British. This was clear from the failed rebellion of Gomdhar Konwar and Piyoli Phukan. Through a completely new revenue system they took control of the economies. In this revenue system the foreign government attached more importance to collection of taxes. They took no measures to erase the sorrows and difficulties of the peasants and poverty ridden subjects. In Assam, in the administrative system prior to that of the British, revenue was not collected through cash. But the introduction of

payment of land revenue as well as other taxes by means of cash by the British further impoverished the Assamese subjects while the exploitation by the British increased day by day. The statistics given below show the increase in revenue in Assam just before the revolt of 1857 (in terms of rupees)

District	1832-33	1842-43	1852-53
Kamrup	1,10,181	2,52,991	2,95,996
Darrang	41,506	1,35,454	1,57,795
Nowgaon	31,509	1,10,318	1,28,873
Sibsagar	—	80,843	1,14,463
Lakhimpur	—	34,780	46,553
Total	1,83,196	6,14,382	7,43,680

The new land revenue policy and the money economy of the British government created deep resentment among the Assamese common people. This money economy led to the creation of the *Mahajans*, who thrived on interests in Assam and the Assamese subject populace was compelled to take out loans on interest from this very class to clear their land revenue to the government. This class of *Mahajans* were the immigrant Marwari (*keya*) and Bengali businessmen.

At that time the villages in Assam were self sufficient and there was hardly any scope of earning money by selling the local produce. Moreover the limited availability of markets also added to the penury of the common people.



**Anandaram Dhekial
Phukan**

The fact that the land revenue struck at the backbone of the Assamese people, was also written by Anandaram Dhekial Phukan in his application to Moffat Mills in 1853. He pointed out that the land revenue fixed by the British was much more than what could be afforded by the peasants.

On the other hand, the British government did not take any measures for the development of agriculture. As such, whenever the climate was unfavourable agriculture suffered and the common people of Assam had to face famines continuously. In his application to Moffat Mills Anandaram Dhekial Phukan mentioned that in 1851 in some areas of Kamrup and Darrang, the condition was such that apart from the family valuables, parents were compelled to sell their own children for a handful of grains. At the

same time in Upper Assam cholera and measles took an epidemic form. Such epidemics led to the annihilation of several villages in Assam in 1839, 1847 and 1852.

In the early part of the 19th century the British had established tea gardens in Upper Assam. To encourage the tea gardeners land revenue of the lands falling within the gardens was exempted. As a result the burden of making up for this loss of revenue fell upon the poor peasants.

Apart from the money economy introduced as a part of the British revenue policy, certain other factors also contributed to the pathetic condition of the Assamese subject populace. For example, like in the other states of India, in Assam too, the British administration was responsible for the deterioration of the cottage industry. From the time of the Ahom dynasty the *Paat* and *Muga* silk of Assam had a special demand in the Indian market but the patronage of the British administration to import foreign cloth material had a very negative impact on the people associated with this industry.

The condition of the aristocratic class *vis-à-vis* the common people was in no way any better. Some people of the Ahom feudal class had tried to associate themselves with the British administration from the very beginning but due to their lack of modern education the majority could not become a part of the new administration. On the other hand, the British rulers had to import educated Bengali persons from Bengal. As a result, the officials of the Ahom dynasty began to lose their posts and positions very fast while the newly appointed Bengali *Babu's* gradually began to assert their importance in the administrative set up of Assam.

Though some of the Assamese aristocrats who held posts like Phukan, Barua, Rajkhowa etc during the Ahom reign were made *Maujadars* with the responsibility to collect taxes, largely this responsibility was vested upon the outsiders like Bengalis from Srihatta in Bengal or Marwaris from western India. This act of the British not only deprived the Assamese aristocratic class, but is also alleged to have created a riot like situation under the domination of the outsiders.

The Assamese aristocrats during the Ahom rule had led a luxurious life with servants galore to cater for their whims and fancies. But, the British stopped slavery in Assam in 1843 and as a result this class suffered from the dearth of labourers to work in their estates and fields. Naturally, this class which lost its privileged social position and power was dissatisfied with the new administration. They felt humiliated on being

compelled to perform manual labour in their own fields and other works like their erstwhile slaves.

At the same time it cannot be concluded that the abolition of slavery by the British led to the uplift of the slaves and labourers of the Ahom rule. It was to engage this group of people as labourers in the newly established tea gardens of the British that they had been freed from the control of the Assamese aristocrats. No immediate measures were adopted for the benefit of these people. Consequently, this class of people cannot be said to have been satisfied with the British rule.

According to eminent Historian H.K Borpujari, several Brahmin *Purohits* of Upper Assam joined in the revolt of 1857 against the British rule because the government took away the excess of the *Lakheraj* and untaxed lands which they had been occupying and enjoying since ages and also fixed revenue on the remaining lands. It was natural that this class of people went against the British rule.

From the above discussion it can be concluded that the East India Company's rule that had already completed three decades prior to the revolt of 1857 could not satisfy any section of the common people. The rebellions of Gomdhar konwar, Piyoli Phukan or Gadadhar in the initial years of the British rule were expressions of dissatisfaction of the Ahom aristocratic class against the foreign rule. These rebellions were confined to that class and the common people had no participation in them. But in the years following the repression of these rebellions, the accumulated dissatisfaction against the British rule percolated down to the common people. The Assamese common people were now beginning to rise against the domination and exploitation of the British rule.

3.1 : Revolt of 1857 in India and its impact on Assam

1857 is a year that needs special mention in the history of Modern India. It was in this year that the Indian soldiers recruited into the British army declared mutiny and shook the foundations of the British rule in India. The imperialist policies of the British like the Subsidiary Alliance of Lord Wellesley, Doctrine of Lapse of Lord Dalhousie etc led to the incorporation of many Indian Kingdoms into the British Empire. The deprived rulers of these kingdoms and their supporters gave full support to the mutiny of the Indian soldiers which broke out on 10 May 1857 in protest of their various miseries and strengthened the revolt. Mughal Emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar II, Nana Saheb of Kanpur, Maratha leader Tantia Tope, Rani Lakshmi Bai of Jhansi etc. led this revolt. The



Rani Lakshmi Bai
of Jhansi

revolutionaries wanted to place Bahadur Shah Zafar II as the Mughal Emperor once again and end the British rule in India forever.

It has already been discussed that the Assamese common people were rising against the domination and exploitation of the British. The revolt of 1857 gave a golden opportunity to the elite class of Assam to throw off the yoke of British rule and reestablish the Ahom monarchy. That is why the revolt of 1857 led to reactions in Assam. Some people of the Brahmaputra valley tried to instigate the Indian soldiers in the British army based in Assam to fan the fires of the revolt here and with their help chase away the British and install a Prince from the Ahom royal family as the King of Assam. In the Barak valley also some soldiers from Chittagong revolted against the British.

When the revolt broke out in North India, there were two British army regiments posted in Assam- The First Assam Light Infantry in Dibrugarh and The Second Assam Light Infantry in Gauhati. Though at first the sepoys of both these regiments were indifferent, the news of the sepoy mutiny in Bihar resulted in some amount of dissatisfaction spreading among the Dibrugarh-Gauhati regiments and also in the sepoy barracks of Sibsagar and Saikhowa.

Revolt of Moniram Dewan :

The people who tried to instigate the sepoys against the British government were members of the erstwhile elite class of Assam who were dreaming of throwing out the British from Assam and reinstating the Ahom monarchy with the grandson of former Ahom King Purandar Singha, Kandarpeswar Singha, as the King. The person who planned this was Maniram Barbhandar Barua who was more popular as Maniram Dewan. When the Indian soldiers declared mutiny in Meerut, Maniram Dewan was in Calcutta. He had gone there to file an application to the British government requesting that a portion of Upper Assam be placed under the rule of a scion of the Ahom royal family.

In Calcutta Maniram Dewan met Madhu Mallik, a Bengali *Mukhtiyar* and together they hatched a conspiracy to drive the British out of Assam. Bahadur Gaonburha, Phormud Ali, Piyoli Barua, Dutiram Barua, Mayaram Nazir etc were some elites of Assam who responded to Maniram Dewan's appeal. It was decided that Ahom Prince Kandarpeswar Singha would lead the soldiers in Assam in revolt and Maniram Dewan would bring arms and weapons from Calcutta to help them.

The British government got a scent of this conspiracy in the middle of August 1857. Accordingly preparations were made to apprehend the rebels. Understanding the seriousness of the matter Chief Commissioner Jenkins requested the government to send a force of trained European soldiers.

In the first part of September 1857 the Principal Assistant Captain Holroyd intercepted many letters written by Maniram Dewan wherein the conspiracy against the British government was clearly mentioned. On the request of Holroyd Captain Louthar arrived at Jorhat with a force and arrested Kandarpeswar Singha on September 7. He was sent off to Calcutta and kept in Alipur jail.

Immediately after this Maniram Dewan was arrested in Calcutta. He was the main leader of the conspiracy against the British. He was kept in the Alipur jail for about two and a half months and then sent to Jorhat in December.

Captain Holroyd set up a special Court of Justice wherein Maniram Dewan and Piyoli Barua were sentenced to be hanged to death on being found guilty of charges of conspiring against the British government. And on 26 February 1858 both of them were hanged. Madhu Mallik, Kamala Barua, Dutiram Barua, Mayaram Nazir etc were sentenced to be imprisoned for life. Bahadur Gaonburha and Sheikh Formud Ali were sent away to the Andamans and all their properties were confiscated.

Those soldiers who took part in this revolt were also punished. For example, some soldiers of Dibrugarh regiment were imprisoned for life while some soldiers of Golaghat were dismissed from service.

The Ahom prince Kandarpeswar Singha was a minor and as such he was kept in the special jail in Bardhaman till 1860. Later on he was allowed to come back to Gauhati where he set up residence. He was not permitted by the British government to go back to Jorhat. He was given a pension of 500 rupees with effect from 1853.

After the Queen's Proclamation of 1858, Dutiram Barua, Sheikh Formud Ali, Bahadur Gaonburha etc were allowed to come back to Assam from the Andamans.

In this manner the attempt of Maniram Dewan in 1857 to overthrow the British in Assam and re-establish the Ahom Monarchy ended in failure.

Maniram Dewan's personality and life story

Maniram Borbhandar Barua came to be known as Maniram Dewan. He had not only been a witness to the Burmese invasion of Assam and how the Assamese people had suffered but also to how the British came to lord over Assam in 1826. Initially he was not opposed to the British rule. In fact in 1828 he had been appointed as *Shirastadar* (Revenue Book keeper) by the British in Jorhat. While working in this position he brought in many reforms in the Revenue department and proved his capacity. When King Purandar Singha was re-established in Upper Assam, Maniram Barua joined his service as the *Dewan*. But for reasons unknown, he resigned from this post



and joined in the Assam Tea Company, which was owned by the British and established in 1839. In 1844 he resigned from there as well and set up his own tea garden in Jorhat. The fact that he could not gain any exemption from revenue payment like the British tea growers agitated him. Moreover, Captain Holroyd who joined as the Chief Officer of Sibsagar district in 1851, deprived Maniram's family of the revenue that they had been enjoying since generations. Although the career of Maniram Dewan as an authoritative officer began under the British government but it was also under the same government that he was reduced to a common man devoid of post, position, wealth and prestige.

Maniram Dewan realized one thing that his fortunes would not change for the better under the British domination. For that to happen the Ahom Monarchy had to be restored. Like the Ahom Prince Kameswar Singha, Maniram Dewan too, refused to accept the pension of 1000 rupees from the British. When Kameswar Singha expired in 1851, Maniram Dewan fully supported the idea of establishing his son, Kandarpeswar Singha on the royal throne.

In 1853, when the Chief Justice of the Calcutta High Court, Moffat Mills came to Assam to investigate the administrative situation, Maniram Dewan presented two applications before him. In one of these, he gave an account of his services rendered to the British company and requested the government for some suitable remuneration. In the other, he requested that Ahom Prince Kandarpeswar Singha be reinstated on the Ahom royal throne and also the details of the sufferings and miseries of the aristocratic class. In this application

though he mentioned about some positive effects of the British rule in Assam like-the end of severe punishment like body mutilation during the Ahom rule, he also pointed out some negative effects like-awarding pension to undeserving people, reducing the elite high officials to the standard of the common people by depriving them of all their privileges.

Though on the basis of his applications, Mills critically examined all aspects of the English government, he did not sympathize with Maniram's applications. In fact, he declared Maniram to be a conspirator.

The report of Mills dashed all hopes of Maniram Dewan and he completely turned against the British. As he understood his own limitations, he decided to avoid a direct confrontation with the British government and in early part of 1857 went to Calcutta to appeal to the British government to restore Kandarpeswar Singha on the throne of Assam. But He never got an opportunity to meet the Lieutenant Governor of Bengal.

At that time he came to know about the revolt of the Indian soldiers in the British army in Northern India and began to dream of overthrowing the British rule in Assam with the help of the Indian soldiers in the British army posted in Assam through a revolt. He sent some secret letters from Calcutta to Kandarpeswar Singha in Jorhat and some other trusted people. In these letters he advised that the Indian soldiers in Dibrugarh and Golaghat be contacted and a revolt raised. Maniram Dewan planned to come to Upper Assam with arms and ammunitions during the time of Durga puja and join in the revolt. Unfortunately, many of these conspiratory letters fell into the hands of the officer of Sibsagar district, Captain Holroyd and Maniram Dewan was immediately arrested in Calcutta. His supporters in Jorhat and Sibsagar like Piyoli Barua, Kandarpeswar Singha and others were arrested. Maniram Dewan and Piyoli Barua were kept in Jorhat Jail and hanged on 26 February 1858.

3.1.01 : Causes of the failure of the revolt of 1857

From the above discussion it can be surmised that in spite of political and organizational efforts Maniram Dewan and his associates could not ignite the fire of the revolt in Assam like in Northern India.

First of all the number of rebels in Assam was very small. Maniram Dewan's supporters were confined to Jorhat and Sibsagar. He hardly gained any support in Nowgaon, Kamrup and Gauhati.

Second, the leaders of the rebellion failed to understand the importance of time and so, even after completion of all preparations

for the revolt, they failed to begin in time. As a result the British government gained a lot of valuable time for defence.

Third, The chief organizer of the revolt, Maniram Dewan was far away from the scene of revolt. At that time Calcutta was very far away from Assam and to command a revolt from there, through letters, was quite impractical. Maniram Dewan should have arrived in Assam at the earliest. No doubt he had been an able administrator but he lacked the expertise to be the leader of a revolt. Maniram Dewan can be said to have been the best example of what happens when the leader of a revolt underestimates the strength of the opposition or fails to appreciate their ability and intelligence.

Fourth, Maniram Dewan and his associates never tried to involve all sections of the society in the revolt. The new Assamese middle class people of Nowgaon and Gauhati were not at all sympathetic towards the revolt. At that time the newly emerging Assamese middle class intelligentsia was more attracted towards the Bengali middle class lifestyle. They had no wish to go back under the administration of the Ahom monarchy again. As such, this group of people of Assam neither supported nor showed any sympathy towards the revolt of 1857. Consequently, though there was some bubbling in the name of the revolt but there was no explosion as such.

Fifth, the rebels of Assam failed to maintain the secrecy of their activities. As a result the British government came to know about their entire conspiracy and could successfully suppress the revolt.

Sixth, the rebels in Assam had no access to arms and ammunitions as was required. Though Maniram Dewan was supposed to bring arms and weapons, he was arrested before he could do so.

Last, the Indian soldiers of the British army posted in Assam did not form the backbone of the revolt in Assam. The rebels in Assam could not gain the support of these soldiers as in Meerut, Delhi and Lucknow.

All the reasons mentioned above led to the fact that the revolt of 1857 had no serious impact in Assam. Whatever little impact was there was completely eradicated by the British government.

3.1.02 : Importance of the Revolt of 1857 in Assam

Though the revolt of 1857 was crushed by the British with an iron hand, this was for the first time in the history of Assam that Assam was associated with a historical Indian event.

Second, the peasant revolts that began in 1861 in Assam got

inspiration from the revolt of 1857.

Third, in Assam too, the Hindu and Muslim communities were united to take part in the revolt and thus fuelled the growth of Nationalism.

During the Indian National Movement the freedom fighters of Assam were inspired by the activities of Maniram Dewan and his associates in the revolt of 1857.

3.2 : Rise of Peasant's Revolt in Assam

After the suppression of the Revolt of 1857 all powers of the East India Company were transferred to the Queen of England through the Queen's Proclamation of 1858. The Revolt had led to a pitiable economic condition of the British government. Since a huge amount had to be spent in the name of suppressing the Revolt, the deficit budget of 1857-58 rose to 14 million pounds. And so in the years following the Revolt the British government was most concerned about how to stabilize their economic condition and make up the deficit. As a result the burden of taxes fell on the Indian masses. In Assam also the same policy was adopted and this led to several additional taxes over and above those already there. Between 1854 and 1870 there was a hundred percent rise in taxes. Stamp Duties in 1858, Income Tax, License Tax (for using forest products like wood, bamboo etc) and Grazing Tax (for grazing cattle in the fields and meadows) in 1860 were introduced. In Kamrup, Darrang and Nowgong excise duties were imposed. Rivers in which gold was found and fishing was done were now auctioned. All these measures of the British government to collect more and more revenue badly affected the common people and peasants. It has already been mentioned that though taxes were collected from the peasants, no steps were taken by the government for the development of agriculture and the agriculturists. The foreign government did not exempt the peasants from payment of taxes even during natural disasters, epidemics or famines. As a result of all this, the common people of Assam were totally disgusted with the British government and this led to a series of peasant revolts in Assam from the middle of the 19th century.

3.2.01 : Raij Mel

The peasant revolts in Assam in the 19th century were led by the *Raij Mels* (People's Assembly). These were in no way any kind of political organizations and yet their importance in Assam was immense. These *Raij Mels* did their best to make the peasants and other common people politically conscious. These assemblies grew under the supervision of the leading personalities of the society like

the *Gaonburha*, *Doloi* and *Gosain* etc and worked under their directions. These assemblies were not limited to a single village like a *panchayat*; they comprised of several villages. Everyone, irrespective of caste, creed, community or religion could participate in these assemblies. This in itself gave a unique character to the *Raij Mels*. There is a proverb in Assamese- “*Raijei Roja, Gyatiyei Ganga*”, which exalts the power and positions of the public and community. The *Raij Mels* reflected this proverb in the real sense. It was in these public assemblies that people learnt how to take unanimous public decisions and also, how to democratically demand the government that their decisions are implemented.

The *Raij Mels* were an intimate part of the Assamese rural life particularly in solving various problems right from the days of the Ahom Monarchy down to the British rule. It was the *Raij Mels* that awakened the peasants in various places of Nowgaon, Kamrup and Darrang against the British policy of exploitation which led to the British local administration being paralysed.

3.2.02 : Phulaguri Dhawa (1861)

The banner of revolt that was raised for the first time in Assam by the exploited peasants against the British policy of economic exploitation was the *Phulaguri Dhawa*. Located near Nowgaon, Phulaguri was a village inhabited by the *Tiwa* ethnic community who survived on the commercial cultivation of Poppy. When the British government began to sell opium (which was extracted from the Poppy seeds) these peasants were naturally infuriated. In 1861, the British government completely banned the cultivation of Poppy. This agitated the *Tiwa* ethnic community and more so, because the selling of opium by the British government continued. The British administration's decision adversely impacted upon the economic condition of this community. Another news that made rounds was that the government would impose tax on *Tamul-paan* (Areca nut and betel leaves) also.

As soon as the news of banning Poppy cultivation spread, on 17th September 1861, more than 1500 peasants from the various adjoining areas gathered in Phulaguri and organized a *Raij Mel* to oppose this decision of the government. In the *Mel* it was decided to submit a petition to the Deputy Commissioner requesting the removal of the ban on Poppy cultivation and not to fix any tax on *Tamul-paan*.

At that time the Deputy Commissioner of Nowgaon was Herbert

Sconce. Instead of showing any sympathy towards the public, he misbehaved with them. To protest against this, the public held *Raij Mels* for five consecutive days from 15th October in Phulaguri. The 1000 strong peasants who gathered on the first day were mostly armed with bamboo sticks. In the following days the number of gathered public increased and on 18th October about 4000 people had gathered. Deputy Commissioner Sconce sent his Assistant Commissioner Lieutenant Singer to the meeting. When Singer inquired about the objectives of the meeting, one Jati Kalita explained on behalf of the public that since the local authorities had not shown any sympathy towards the demands of the peasants, namely to remove the ban on Poppy cultivation and not to fix taxes on *Tamul-paan*, they were now planning to approach the highest authorities. Singer became very excited at this and ordered the people to leave. Moreover, he also ordered his sepoys to snatch away the bamboo sticks carried by the peasants. While this tussle over the bamboo sticks broke out, one peasant struck Singer on the head with his stick and felled him to the ground. When the other peasants also joined in this attack, Singer died on the spot. His body was thrown into the Kollong river. The police force that had accompanied Singer fled the scene. This incident has been mentioned in the pages of history as the *Phulaguri Dhawa*.

After this incident many peasants were arrested by the authorities on the charge of the murder of Singer. Thousands were kept imprisoned in temporary jails in Raha and Phulaguri. As a result of the trial Lakkhan Deka, Songbor Lalung and Rongbor Deka were awarded death sentence. Some of the accused peasants were sent away to *Koliyapani* (Andamand and Nicobar Islands).

The importance of *Phulaguri Dhawa* in history :

Though the British authorities tried to dismiss the *Phulaguri dhawa* as an ordinary revolt of the opium addicted peasants against the government's banning of Poppy cultivation in Assam, in reality this revolt had far reaching consequences.

First, the voluntary participation of the *Lalung (Tiwa)* ethnic community and the *Kaibartta* (fishing) community in this revolt gave it a mass character. The peasants were successful in getting the support of other classes of people- the educated elite Assamese middle class, exploited by the increase in land revenue, businessmen and some *Maujadars*- though indirectly, extended their support to the rebels. The then Commissioner of Assam, Major Henry Hopkinson admitted

that if 50 soldiers from the 2nd Light Infantry in Tezpur and 80 soldiers from Gauhati had not been brought to suppress the revolt, it would have kept on spreading. Then it would have been very difficult to control it. Altogether it can be said that this revolt had been successful because after this the government never imposed any taxes on *Tamul-paan*.

Second, the *Phulaguri* revolt was an example of the common people's attempt to free themselves from the clutches of the British imperialism. The aristocratic class of the Ahom Monarchy (who lost their power and privileges under the British and had already taken part in the revolt of 1857-58) also joined in this revolt.

The *Phulaguri* revolt attracted the attention of every section of the society and the decision of the public of *Phulaguri* not to pay any revenue can be termed as the beginning of the non-cooperation movement. Later on, this same mechanism was adopted by Mahatma Gandhi during the Freedom struggle.

Third, the *Phulaguri* peasant revolt was an inspiration for the peasants of other parts of Assam to think about their miseries in an organized manner. As a result, a few years later the peasants of various areas of Darrang and Kamrup district raised the banner of a series of revolt against the oppression and deprivation by the British government.

3.3 : Peasant Revolt of Lower Assam

Even after the *Phulaguri* peasant revolt the British government did not take any measures to wipe away the miseries of the peasants nor did they learn any lesson from this incident. In 1868-69 land revenue had increased between 25 to 50%. When in 1892, the Chief Commissioner of Assam, Sir William Ward, increased the land revenue by 100% and arranged strict measures for its collection, the peasants lost control over their patience. The consequent series of peasant revolts that began in Assam in the last decade of the 19th century, December 1893 to be precise, came to be known as the **Assam Riots**. The peasants of Rangia and Lasima in Kamrup district, and Patharughat in Darrang district decided not to pay taxes (no tax campaign) to the British government. The peasants who organized themselves through the *Raij Mels* even went on to declare that those peasants who opposed this decision would be socially ostracized. It may be mentioned here that this revolt was not only against the British rule but also against the Marwari (keya) *Mahajans* who exploited the peasants by mortgaging their lands against financial loans.

3.3.01 : The Peasant Revolt of Rangia

On 24th December 1893 the peasant revolt began with the looting and vandalizing of the Rangia bazaar. On 30th December hundreds of peasants from and around Rangia humiliated the *Tehsildaar* of Rangia and Tamulpur, Radhanath Barua and destroyed shops, houses etc of Rangia *Haat*. They also looted the land mortgage papers of the peasants from the interest-mongering Marwari *Mahajans*. The peasants felt that the presence of the Marwaris had led to the increase in land revenue. The government had to send an armed force to control the situation but the Police Superintendent Riley could not muster the courage to arrest any of the peasant leaders because the protestors were very well organized. On 8th January 1894, the Police arrested 15 peasants from a *Raij Mel* which had been called to discuss how they would place their problems and miseries before the Deputy Commissioner. On the 10th of January about 3000 peasants from various *mouja* gathered in front of the Rangia Police Station. When the Deputy Commissioner McCabe ordered them to leave, they refused to budge. By evening, the peasants began to move closer to the Police Station hoping that the Deputy Commissioner might give some notice regarding reduction of land revenue. They also began to demand the release of their associates who had been arrested. When the Deputy Commissioner asked for a peasant representative to discuss the issues, the peasants shouted in a chorus that they would not pay the revenue at the increased rate. The peasants then, tried to forcefully enter the Police Station and McCabe ordered the Police to open fire. This compelled the peasants to retreat. On 10th January McCabe ordered through a notification that henceforth no public meetings will be allowed to be held without the permission of the Deputy Commissioner. The Deputy Commissioner then selected some leaders from the peasants and appointed them as Police constables. These people were then used not only to establish peace among the peasants but also to convince them to pay revenue to the government. These measures of the Deputy Commissioner must be said to have been successful because out of the 90,000/ Rupees that the peasants of Rangia had to pay to the government, 60,000/ Rupees was paid as the first instalment. Even then, the repressive policy of the British could not stop the peasants from holding public meetings. Peasants in Nalbari, Barama, Bajali etc continued to be as active as earlier and did their best to set up all hurdles for the government in revenue collection.

3.3.02 : Peasant Revolt of Lachima

The severe repression of the peasant revolt of Rangia by the British government could not stop it from spreading to other regions. The *Raij Mels* in Barama were very strong and here they created a force armed with stout sticks. In addition, for better communication they appointed postmen who not only carried messages but also acted as spies. In the Bajali region, comprising Lachima, Choukhuti, Panagaon, Sarthebari, Patacharkuchi etc, thousands of peasants participated in the *Raij Mels*. The largest *Raij Mel* in this entire region was held in Panagaon *sapori*. In this assembly peasants from various places like Rangia, Nalbari, Dharmapur, Bajali etc of North Kamrup took part. On 21st January 1894, when Dasuram Choudhury, the *Moujadar* of Kapla village near Lachima in Sarukhetri *Mouja*, and his *Mondol* Holiram Mishra went out to collect revenue, they were very badly beaten up by the people. After some days the *Moujadar* died. Arriving at the scene, the Circle Officer of Barpeta, Madhab Chandra Bordoloi arrested 75 persons and took them to his rest camp in Lachima. When, about 3000 people surrounded the rest camp and threatened to burn it down, he was compelled to release the arrested persons. The next day, Deputy Commissioner McCabe arrived there with about 30 policemen and soldiers from the Gorkha regiment. He arrested 59 rebel peasants and locked them up in a temporary jail. On 25th, around 6000 people signed a document demanding the release of the imprisoned persons and submitted it in the Deputy Commissioner's camp. McCabe showed no sympathy; instead by applying force, he chased away the crowd. Among those arrested were many leaders like Gosain Doley. These people were tied to the yokes like bullocks and paraded before the public as a lesson, so that no one might revolt in the future. 16 people were given various kinds of punishments for committing the crime of organizing the peasant revolt in Lachima and assaulting Holiram Mishra Mondal. Later, on the orders of the Calcutta High Court, the punishment sentenced for these people was reduced. Two years of rigorous imprisonment was awarded to Pushparam Kalita, Debi Dutta Sarma, Jayanti Bez, Nirbhasa Kalita and Monglu Kalita for organizing and leading the revolt.

3.3.03 : Peasant Revolt of Patharughat

The peasant revolt of North Kamrup had hardly cooled down when another peasant revolt began in Patharughat in the Mangaldoi circle of Darrang district. Right from the middle of January 1894, the public

had organized *Raij Mels* to oppose the increased revenue as well as its collection. The peasants of Kalaigaon, Mangaldi, Sipajhar of Mangoldoi circle and Patharughat *tehsil* gathered in these *Raij Mels*. After holding such public assemblies in their own areas, the peasants were planning a huge public assembly for three days, 26-28 January, in Patharughat. This news travelled from the *Tehsildars* of that area to the Circle Officer who in turn informed the Deputy Commissioner, J. D Anderson, about this proposed *Raij Mel*. In order to stop this huge public assembly, J. D Anderson, along with a force comprising of police and military personnel and the Police Superintendent J. R Berington, arrived in Patharughat on 27th January.

With the help of the police and military, the properties of those peasants who had refused to pay revenue, were confiscated. This infuriated the peasants and about 200 of them surrounded Berington who had gone for the revenue extraction. He somehow managed to save himself from the clutches of the public and reaching the Rest Camp, described everything to the Deputy Commissioner. A few hours later around 2000 peasants marched towards the Rest Camp. Almost each one of them was armed with sticks.

When the peasants reached the Rest Camp, Anderson advised them to go home as soon as possible but they did not move. At this the Deputy Commissioner ordered the Police Superintendent to disperse the peasants by using force, if necessary. Following this order when the Police Superintendent tried to forcefully chase away the peasants, they retaliated by brandishing their sticks, hurling stones-pebbles and moved in closer. The raining of stones and pebbles was such that the police-military and administrative officers, none could keep their eyes open. Under such conditions the Deputy Commissioner ordered the Police Superintendent to open fire. According to unofficial records, 140 peasants were killed and 150 peasants were injured as a result of the firing. On the other hand the official records showed 15 killed and 37 injured.

The peasant revolt of Patharughat was crushed by the British imperialist government with an iron hand. On account of participating in this revolt, according to official sources, 37 peasants were arrested and tried. The Circle Officer of Mangaldoi, Mr. Ransom settled these cases. Aklu Sheikh and six others were punished and the rest were all released.

The peasant revolts of the 19th century in Assam were no doubt successfully subjugated by the British government, but the series of

revolts that began from 1861, were a great source of inspiration for the Assamese common people later, when the freedom struggle started.

3.4 : Ethnic(Tribal) Revolt

From the beginning of the British rule in Assam, one by one, revolts had been taking place. Like the peasant revolts in the valleys, parallel revolts had been going on among the ethnic tribes of the hills also against the colonial rule of the British.

3.4.01 : Jaintia Revolt

The Jaintia Kingdom went into the hands of the British from the Jaintia King, Rajendra Singha in 1835. The freedom loving Jaintia people were infuriated by this act of incorporating the Jaintia Hills within the Company's domain. More than the loss of land, it was the high-handed attitude of the British that agitated the Jaintias or Syntengs. Under the British Political Agent, the *Diwani* and *Faujdari* responsibilities were vested in the *Dolois* but the foreign administration always tried to find their faults. The British made arrangements to extract revenue by banning community fishing and collection of firewood which was common among these people. Moreover, interference in the religious and traditional social practices and banning the use of weapons that had been used for generations, turned this ethnic hill tribe completely against the British. They organized village meetings with the *Dolois* and *Sardars* and began to prepare for revolt. On the other hand the British to establish their authority, began to impose taxes like House tax, Income Tax etc on these people who had never ever paid any tax in cash.

When the British implemented House tax the Jaintia's raised the banner of revolt by removing the *tehsildar* of Jowai. As soon as the news spread, revolts were declared in Jayantipur, Mulagul, Jafalong, and Sera areas also. The British administration adopted stern measures. In retaliation the Jaintia's under the leadership of Ukiang Nonbah doubled the strength of the revolt. They met in a meeting near Jowai, where they swore to overthrow the British authority from the Jaintia Hills and re-establish their own rights. On 17th January 1862, the Jaintia's made a sudden attack on the British Camp in Jowai. The rebels had already blocked the two roads connecting Jowai-Cherrapunji and Cherrapunji-Jayantipur. The 44th Native Infantry and 33rd Bengal Military Police forces deployed by the British administration had been torturing the people inhumanly. The rebels too, killed many of their opponents. In the midst of this violent conflict between the two sides,

the British administration entrusted the military and civil authority of the entire Jaintia Hills with the Brigadier General of the Eastern Command, G. D Showers. In addition B. W Morton was appointed as the Deputy Commissioner of the Khasi-Jaintia Hills. The continuous attacks from the government side was leading to the gradual erosion of the strength of the rebels. The British government promised a general amnesty if the rebels surrendered voluntarily and an award of 1000/ rupees was announced for anyone who would capture and hand over to the British their leader, Ukiang Nongbah, alive. At last Ukiang Nongbah was captured by the British and in the presence of a huge crowd, he was hanged to death in Jowai. This incident dampened the spirit of the rebels to a large extent and many of them surrendered voluntarily. In this manner by 1863 the Jaintia Revolt came to an end.

3.4.02 : North Cachar Revolt

Among the revolts raised by the ethnic hill tribes during the British rule towards the end of the 19th century, the revolt in North Cachar hills under the leadership of Sambhudhan Kachari must be mentioned. The center of this revolt was Maibang. This revolt went on for one year between 1881-82. In 1880, the British government formed a Kuki force of 100 Kuki men to counter an attack on North Cachar by the Angami Nagas. In addition, an English Officer was also appointed to control the ethnic people of this area. These were the reasons that led to this revolt under the leadership of Sambhudhan Kachari.

In this revolt, the rebels destroyed the houses built by the British by burning them down. In Gunjung they killed the orderlies of two British Officers and a Police Officer. After this, the rebels suddenly attacked the government forces in Maibang. In the violent conflict between the two sides, many of the rebels lost their lives. Major Boyd, a British Officer, who was seriously injured, later died. There is no information as to what happened to the leader of this revolt, Sambudhan Kachari.

3.4.03 : Revolt of the Nagas

The British political control was not acceptable to the Nagas also. As a result, in the British dominated Naga territories, winds of dissatisfaction began to blow from the very beginning. The Nagas proved their love of independence when, in 1878 they killed a British Officer Damante and his security. Kohima was blocked by the rebels for several days. This revolt of the Angami Nagas was crushed with an iron hand by Colonel Johnston.

3.5 : Revolt in Manipur

The kingdom of Manipur was outside the administration of Assam. Since many years Manipur was recognized as a native Kingdom under the protection of the British. In 1890, an internal quarrel broke out in the Manipuri royal family for the Throne. In this struggle among the successors, the Chief Commissioner of Assam interfered unnecessarily. Taking advantage of the presence of the British, the Crown Prince Kulachandra, dethroned the king, Surachandra and sat on the throne himself on 21st September 1890. Though the King Surachandra appealed for help to the British, the latter recognized Kulachandra as the king of Manipur. Thereafter the British began to put pressure on Kulachandra to banish his Commander-in-Chief (*Senapati*) Tikendrajit, who was the main leader of the anti-British revolt which was secretly going on, from the kingdom. But to banish the popular leader who was working to protect the freedom of the Kingdom, on the direction of the British, was not an easy task for Kulachandra. When the Chief Commissioner of Assam, J. W. Quinton and four other European officers came to Manipur themselves to capture Tikendrajit, the freedom seeking Manipuris killed all of them. To avenge this incident a strong military contingent was sent to Manipur. Tikendrajit was successfully captured by the British force and on the charges of anti-British activities and killing British Officials, he was hanged. King Kulachandra was exiled and a minor Manipuri prince, Churachandra was declared to be the King in September 1891. The Political Agent of the British government was given all responsibilities of the administration of Manipur since the King was a minor. Manipur had to pay Rs. 2.50 Lakh to the British government as compensation for the losses incurred during the revolt. In addition, a sum of Rs. 50,000 had to be paid annually by Manipur to the British. In this way, the British established their domination in the Kingdom of Manipur.

S U M M A R Y



In Assam, right from 1826, when the English rule was established, various political revolts were organized to end the foreign domination. After the revolt of Gomdhar Konwar and Gadadhar in 1828-30, Assam also felt the impact of the pan-Indian revolt in 1857. Under the leadership of Maniram Dewan and taking advantage of the revolt of 1857, the attempt to overthrow the British rule in Assam and seat an Ahom prince on the throne had failed. Maniram Dewan and Piyoli Barua were hanged.

- ☞ Towards the end of the 19th century several series of peasant revolts took place in Assam. The first among these was the revolt of Phulaguri in 1861. In this revolt a government officer by the name of Lieutenant Singer was killed by the rebels. The British administration suppressed this revolt with a strong hand.
- ☞ Even after Phulaguri, in 1893-94, the peasants revolted against the increased revenue by the British. These series of revolts took place in Patharughat in Darrang; Rangia, Lachima, Sarthebari etc in Kamrup and various places of lower Assam.
- ☞ The ethnic hill tribes also sought freedom from the British rule and raised the banner of revolt in North Cachar, Nagaland and Manipur etc. This revolt of the ethnic Hill tribes was also crushed by the British.

E X E R C I S E

Very short answer type questions :

1. After the establishment of the British rule in Assam how did the system of revenue collection change?
2. In which year did Moffat Mills come to Assam?
3. Who were the Keyas ?
4. Who led the revolt of 1857 in Assam?
5. Which Ahom Prince did the rebels of Assam want to re-install on the throne in the revolt of 1857?
6. Who was the Bengali *Mukhtiyar* who helped Maniram Dewan?
7. Who was hanged along with Maniram Dewan?
8. Who tried the case of Maniram Dewan?
9. Mention two causes of the failure of the revolt of 1857 in Assam.
10. In which years were the Stamp tax and Income tax implemented?
11. Write two causes of the pitiable condition of the peasants of Assam during the British rule.
12. Who was Lieutenant Singer?
13. When did the *Phulaguri Dhawa* take place?
14. When did the peasant revolt of Rangia take place?
15. Where is Lachima located?
16. When did the peasant revolt of Lachima take place?
17. When did the peasant revolt of Patharughat take place?

18. Who led the Jaintia revolt in 1861?
19. Who led the revolt of the ethnic tribes of North Cachar in 1881?
20. Who punished Tikendrajit with the death sentence?
21. In which year was J.W Quinton murdered?

Long answer type questions :

1. Discuss in brief the causes of the revolt of 1857-58.
2. Discuss the role of Maniram Dewan in the revolt of 1857-58 in Assam.
3. Discuss the reasons why the revolt of 1857-58 failed in Assam.
4. Discuss the importance of the revolt of 1857 in Assam.
5. Write a note on the *Phulaguri Dhawa*.
6. Discuss the peasant revolt of North Kamrup in 1894.
7. Give an account of the peasant revolt of Patharughat in 1894.
8. Write a note on the Jaintia revolt against the British in 1850.
9. Write about the anti-British revolt of 1891 in Manipur under the leadership of Tikendrajit?

Write Short Notes :

1. The Revenue system implemented by the British in Assam.
2. Maniram Dewan.
3. *Phulaguri Dhawa*.
4. Peasant revolt of Lachima.
5. Battle of Patharughat .
6. Importance of peasant revolts in Assam.
7. Tikendrajit.



Chapter-4

INDIAN FREEDOM MOVEMENT AND NATIONAL AWAKENING IN ASSAM

KEY POINTS

- **Growth of Assamese Nationalism and Formation of Literary Associations and Socio-political Organisations**
- **Role of Assam in the National Movement for Independence**
- **Ministry of Gopinath Bordoloi**
- **Some Post-Independence Institutions**

4.00 : Growth of Assamese Nationalism

The first Anglo-Burmese war took place in 1825. After the expulsion of the Burmese from Assam, Yandaboo Treaty was signed on 24th February 1826. It resulted in the political annexation of Assam by the East India Company (EIC). After the Sepoy Mutiny, India came under the direct rule of the British Crown on the basis of Queen's Proclamation of 1858. The period from 1826 to 1858 is known as Company Raj in Assam. The British annexation of Assam led to economic and political restructuring of the region. The introduction of English education had dual impact on Indian society. On one hand, it helped the educated indigenous class to critically question their tradition and on the other hand it facilitated the growth of national awareness. Like in other parts of India,

by the end of the 19th century, voice of dissent against colonial dominance began to stir the people of Assam. Gradually the voice of dissent against the British rule found expression in the writings of several prominent personalities of the time arousing feelings of nationalism in the region. Several socio-cultural organisations were formed to highlight the problems and aspirations of the common people.

4.01 : Asomiya Bhasa Unnati Sadhini Sabha

By the middle of the 19th century, Assam witnessed the growth of a newly emerged educated Assamese middle class. Another significant development of the period was the growth of national awareness. As a result, the new middle class made efforts to organise itself. One of the earliest associations was the *Gyan Pradayini Sabha* initiated by Anandaram Dhekiyal Phukan and Gunaviram Barua in 1857. Anandaram Dhekiyal Phukan strongly opposed the introduction of the Bengali language in schools, offices and courts in place of Assamese in 1836. Consequently, there had been heated debate in the press regarding the independent status of the Assamese language and re-establishing it in schools and offices. This movement for the Assamese language eventually led to the growth of cultural regeneration in Assam. It was only in 1873 the Assamese language was re-established. However, in the process language became a marker of Assamese nationalism.

In Calcutta we find more strong initiatives by the students from Assam to form associations in order to improve the Assamese language and literature. The first known association formed in Calcutta was the *Assamese Literary Society* established in 1872 under the leadership of Devicharan Barua and Gangagovinda Phukan. The proclaimed objective of the society was literary, yet it also played a political role. In 1872, two of its illustrious members, Jagannath Barua and Manik Chandra Barooah, on behalf of the society submitted a memorandum to the Viceroy, Lord Northbrook appealing to take necessary steps for the development of the natural resources of Assam and linking Assam with Bengal by railway. The Society was active till 1885.

With the growing attacks on the Assamese language in the Bengali press the Assamese students in Calcutta felt the need to organise an association to enrich the Assamese language and literature. Consequently in 1888, the *Asomiya Bhasa Unnati Sadhini Sabha* was formed and it soon matured into a literary organisation under the able guidance of students like Hemchandra Goswami, Lakshminath Bezbarua, Kanaklal Barua, Ramakanta Barkakati and Chandrakumar Agarwala. The *Asomiya Bhasa*

Unnati Sadhini Sabha aroused a sense of unity and national awareness amongst the Assamese. To develop a strong scientific base for the Assamese language, the *Sabha* took the initiative of adopting a correct and standardised grammatical system in all the vernacular schools of Assam. It also decided to compile a comprehensive social history of Assam and to translate the important Sanskrit works into Assamese. It was due to the initiative of the *Asomiya Bhasa Unnati Sadhini Sabha*, the government undertook the publication of Hemchandra Barua's magnum opus, *Hemkosh*.



Hemchandra Barua,
the author of *Hemkosh*

The *Asomiya Bhasa Unnati Sadhini Sabha* used to hold regular scholarly discussions on various subjects like Assam's history, culture, literature and language. It also sought to establish branches in different parts of Assam. Several Assamese students who returned to Assam after completion of their studies at Calcutta formed branches in Kohima, Tezpur, Dibrugarh, Sibsagar, Nowgong, Golaghat, Barpeta, Goalpara, Jorhat, and Guwahati. The most significant contribution of the *Asomiya Bhasa Unnati Sadhini Sabha* was the publication of their journal, *Jonaki* which ushered in a new era in Assamese literature.

4.02 : Jonaki Age

Jonaki, the mouthpiece of the ABUSS played a significant role in literary and cultural regeneration of Assam. The cultural and literary renaissance started by *Orunodoi* reached its zenith in the pages of *Jonaki*. Chandrakumar Agarwala was the first editor of *Jonaki*. It successfully brought out new literary talents amongst the Assamese intelligentsia of the period. Chandrakumar Agarwala, the editor of *Jonaki*, in the inaugural issue, made it clear that the politics of the rulers was beyond the purview of *Jonaki*. Consequently, *Jonaki* never dabbled in politics, but the articles and poems published in it reflected the nationalistic views of the authors.

One of the recurrent themes of *Jonaki* was the decline of indigenous commerce and industries of Assam after British annexation and about regenerating economic self-dependence. Kanaklal Barua and Kamalakanta Bhattacharya regularly wrote about the economic backwardness of Assam and made urgent appeal to ensure economic



**Hemchandra
Goswami**



**Lakshminath
Bezbarua**



**Chandrakumar
Agarwala**

Trimurti of Jonaki age

progress of Assam. Lakshminath Bezbarua's 'Mor Desh', 'Assam Sangeet', 'Been Boragi' etc. and the writings of Ambikagiri Raychoudhury used to popularise nationalistic sentiments. *Jonaki* was successful in regenerating cultural and social consciousness in Assam.

4.03 : Assam Chatra Sanmilan

The growth of national awareness also inspired the formation of the Asam Chatra Sanmilan and its first session was held on 25 December 1916 at Guwahati under the Presidentship of Lakshminath Bezbarua. The founder secretary was Chandranath Sarma. The chief objective of the Sanmilan was to enrich the mother tongue by contributing towards its development and preservation. The Chatra Sanmilan also attempted at exchanging views amongst all the students of schools and colleges of Assam. At its inception, the Sanmilan kept politics away from its purview, yet many of its leaders supported participation of students in national politics. Though it was not a political organisation, it helped in the growth of a conscious group of Assamese students.

Eminent personalities from different fields like education, politics and literature used to participate in the annual sessions of the Sanmilan. Prominent amongst them were Lakshminath Bezbarua, Padmanath Gohain Baruah, Acharya Prafulla Chandra Ray, and Krishna Kanta Handique. The mouthpiece of Assam Chatra Sanmilan was MILAN. The Sanmilan made remarkable contribution to the growth of Assam's educational, cultural, and literature and also to the growth of national consciousness.

4.04 : Ryot Sabha

By the end of the 19th century, Tezpur Ryot Sabha in Darrang district and Nagaon Ryot Sabha in Nowgong were established to resolve the problems faced by the peasants. In strengthening and executing the action plans of Tezpur Ryot Sabha, Lakshimikanta Barkakoty, Haribilash Agarwala, Lambodar Bora, Bhabanicharan Bhattacharya and many eminent personalities belonging to the newly organised middle class played a major role.

The Ryot Sabha raised its voice against the newly introduced land settlement in Assam by the colonial state. It demanded for the abolition of grazing tax, reduction of land tax, and to ban the migration of peasants from east Bengal. However, the sabha did not play significant role in the peasant movement of 1893-94, which took place at Rangia (Kamrup), Lachima, Sarthebari and Patharughat (Darrang) against the enhancement of land tax.

During Civil Disobedience movement (1930-34), Ryot Sabha was re-established under the guidance of Assam Provincial Congress Committee. Under the banner of Ryot Sabha, the leaders of the Congress attempted at mobilising the peasants. Ryot Sabhas came up in Sibsagar and Darrang districts. The Ryot Sabha of Naduar and Chayduar were very strong between 1930 and 1939. During the period of the Civil Disobedience the most important demand of the Ryot Sabhas was the reduction of land tax by 50 per cent.

To direct all the Ryot Sabhas towards a common goal or objective a central committee, the All Assam Ryot Sabha was formed and its first session was held near Tilikiyam in Jorhat on 8 April 1933 under the presidentship of Congress leader Nabinchandra Bordoloi. In the second session held at Dergaon around 3000 peasants were present. During the period between 1934 and 1939 around 300 Ryot Sabhas were established in different parts of Assam. Gradually, by the end of 1940, the Ryot Sabhas lost its vigour and in many parts the Ryot Sabhas were included within the Provincial Congress Committees.

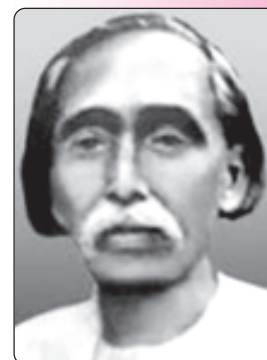
4.05 : Ahom Sabha

The *Ahom Sabha* was formed in 1893 by Padmanath Gohain Baruah. The first session of the Sabha was held at Sibsagar in 1893. One of the first activities of the body was an anti opium campaign. The chief aim of the Sabha was to demand for privilege for the Ahoms in the British administration and to revive their traditional religion, language and social customs, thereby re-establishing cultural identity of the Ahoms. The Sabha also demanded for providing opportunities to the Ahoms by considering them as separate community in terms of economic and educational backwardness.

In 1910, the Sabha was renamed as the Ahom Association. It became overtly political. A significant political demand of the Sabha was – to get recognition for the Ahoms as a minority community and reservation of seats in the Assembly and a separate electorate for Ahoms. The Association worked hard towards this goal throughout 1930s and 40s. In 1941, the Association witnessed internal division amongst its members. A section of them was inspired by the National Congress and formed a separate organisation, Nationalist Ahom Association. It became gradually weak by 1950.

4.06 : Jorhat Sarbajanik Sabha

The *Jorhat Sarbajanik Sabha* was founded in 1884 by Jagannath Barua at Jorhat. It was a landmark in the political associations of Assam.



**Padmanath Gohain
Barua**

The founder President of the Sabha was Raja Naranarayan Simha and Jagannath Barua became the secretary. Barua while studying at Presidency College, Calcutta was inspired by the work of associations like the Atmiya Sabha, Patriot's Association, Indian Association and others in Bengal. He wanted to form similar association in Assam to represent the aspirations and grievances of the people and to pressurise the government to take steps to develop the province. Thus, the chief objectives of the *Jorhat Sarbajanik Sabha* were:

- To represent the aspirations of the people to the government.
- To explain government policies to the people.
- To ameliorate the condition of the people.

Although the Sabha avoided coming into direct confrontation with the government, yet it raised its voice against exploitative government policies. Few such issues taken up by the Sabha were:

1. It raised voice against the introduction of the 'Assam Land and Revenue Regulation Act', 1886.
2. In 1892-93, it took up the cause of the ryots who protested against the enhancement of revenue.
3. In 1893, the Sabha submitted a memorandum to the Royal Commission on Opium asking for gradual abolition of opium in Assam.

The Sabha was strongly against the partition of Bengal in 1905. The Sabha opined that the political future of Assam would be endangered if Assam is annexed with East Bengal. The then Chief Commissioner of Assam Bam Fylde Fuller arrived at Guwahati (Municipality Office) on 1 Nov, 1905 and explained how the partition of Bengal would benefit Assam. Manik Ch. Baruah the Secretary of Assam Association and Jagannath Baruah the president of Jorhat Sarbajanik Sabha were convinced to be benefitted and gave up anti Bengal partition mentality. The Sabha demanded that the interests of the Assamese people should be protected and that certain number of jobs should be reserved for them in the new province. The Sabha became weak after the death of Jagannath Baruah and survived up to 1921.

4.07 : Assam Association

A broad based provincial forum to apprise the Government of the wishes and aspirations of the people of Assam became an urgent need. This led to the formation of the *Assam Association* in 1903 by Manik Chandra Baruah. In 1905, the first session of the Association was held in Dibrugarh. In this session, it formally elected Raja Prabhat Chandra Baruah

as its President, Jagannath Baruah as Vice-President and Manik Chandra Baruah as General Secretary. The Association served as the mouth piece of the people of Assam in presenting to the authorities their '*needs and grievances, hopes and aspirations*'. Until World War I the National Congress had negligible presence in Assam, and the *Assam Association* was the most influential organisation during that period. Like *Jorhat Sarbajanik Sabha*, it did not believe in direct confrontation with the authorities. The Association followed peaceful and constitutional methods to bring change. Some of the members of the Association were also the members of the Legislative Council, and therefore, could influence the government through their speeches and debates on the floor of the Council. Some of the issues raised by the Association were:

1. It was critical of the predominance of government officials in the Municipal Committee and of tea planters in the Local Boards.
2. It demanded democratisation of the local bodies.
3. It opposed enhancement of taxes, excise policy of the government, and demanded absolute prohibition of opium.
4. It was concerned about the development of the province in the field of education. Hence, it negotiated for the representation of Assam in the Calcutta University Syndicate, appointment of Assamese teachers in Cotton College, establishment of technical institutions.

One of the major issues undertaken by the Association was to oppose the incorporation of Assam into a single province named as Eastern Bengal and Assam in 1905. In 1907, the Association submitted a memorandum to the Secretary of State for India to separate Assam from East Bengal. It demanded the introduction of the Montagu- Chelmsford reforms of 1918 in Assam as well. For this purpose the Association sent a team of seven members to Calcutta in 1917. The Association even sent Nabin Chandra Bordoloi and Prasanna Kumar Baruah to London for the same. Due to the pressure built up by the Association, Assam came under the reforms of Montagu-Chelmsford. Another major demand put forward by the Association in 1920 was the demand for the establishment of a university in Assam.

The Assam Association got actively involved in the Non-Cooperation Movement, 1921. Finally its members felt that Association should identify itself with the aims and ideals of the Congress and change its provincial outlook in order to serve the larger interest of the country's ultimate goal in the struggle for freedom. In 1916, the

Association sent delegates to the Indian National Congress and thus established a formal relationship with Congress. The delegates of the Association also attended Nagpur Congress. Over the years, a greater number of delegates from Assam started attending annual conference of the Indian National Congress and in 1921 the Assam association merged with the Assam Provincial Congress Committee.

4.08 : Assam Provincial Congress Committee



**Karmabir Nabin
Chandra Bordoloi**

Like the Indian National Congress, the *Assam Provincial Congress Committee* was also a result of nationalist zeal against British rule. The formation of the Indian National Congress in 1885 marked the beginning of a new era in the freedom movement of India. Many organisations of Assam started sending their representatives to the various sessions of the Congress.

We have already mentioned in the above section that the *Assam Association* had already actively participating in the national politics under the leadership of the Congress. Many of its leaders felt that the Association should identify itself with the aims and ideals of the Congress. At the same time, some other members refused to get amalgamated with the Congress. However, the plans and programmes of the Congress started immensely attracting the middle class. As a result, a discussion to amalgamate the Association with the Congress took place at a meeting of the association held at Jorhat on 18 April, 1921 with Chobilal Upadhyay in the chair. At the initiative of leaders like Chobilal Upadhyay, Nabin Chandra Bordoloi, Krishna Kanta Bhattacharya, Assam Association decided to merge itself in the newly formed *Assam Provincial Congress Committee* in 1921 which was affiliated to the Indian National Congress. It is worth mentioning that the All India Congress Committee in its Nagpur Session in 1920 officially accepted the principle of reorganisation of states on the basis of language which appealed the leaders of Assam as language had been a sensitive issue in Assam.

Subsequently, an ad hoc committee of *Assam Provincial Congress Committee* was formed in June 1921, with its headquarter at Guwahati and Kuladhar Chaliha as its president. Later Tarun Ram Phookan became the president. Under the initiative of the *Assam Provincial Congress Committee*, Gandhi was invited to Assam in 1921 to propagate the message of non-co-operation. His visit tremendously encouraged the congress workers to carry out the non-cooperation movement and implement the principles of Swadeshi. At Pandu in 1926, the 41 All India Congress

Committee session was hosted by the *Assam Provincial Congress Committee*.

In the following years, leaders like Bishnuram Medhi, Siddhinath Sarmah, Maulana Tayebullah, Ambikagiri Raichoudhury and a host of prominent members took the initiative to implement the plans and programmes of the Congress. The first officially elected President of the *Assam Provincial Congress Committee* was Bishnuram Medhi who was elected in 1930 for a period of 9 years. The Congress party could finally secure a major victory in the general elections held in 1946 and Lokapriya Gopinath Bordoloi became the first Premier of the Assam Province. In 1946 when the Cabinet Mission proposed to integrate Assam and the North East into group C with East Bengal, the Congress party under Bordoloi strongly protested against the proposal. Ultimately, Assam was not included in Group C for the movement led by Bordoloi, supported by Gandhi.

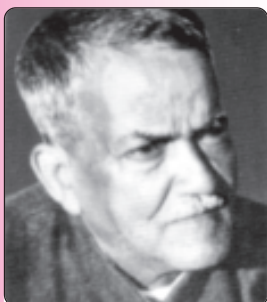
4.09 : Swadeshi Movement and Assam

The new province proposed to be constituted by the British Govt. by combining Assam and Eastern Bengal was first named as Eastern Bengal. Though the vast area of Assam was included in new province, the name 'Assam' was dropped from the title of the province. In other words, Assam was about to lose its identity and existence. The European Tea Planters' Association in Assam was aggrieved with this and objected to this decision. They argued that the name Assam is famous for tea in the international market and it should be there in the name of new province. The British agreed to change the name and the new name became 'Eastern Bengal and Assam.'

The 'Eastern Bengal and Assam' became a province under the Lieutenant Governor right from the implementation of the partition of Bengal on 16 Oct, 1905. The then Commissioner of Assam Fuller became the Lt. Governor of the new province. At the same time the capital of Assam was shifted from Shillong to Dhaka, Dhaka became the new capital of 'Eastern Bengal and Assam'.

The attitude of 'Jorhat Sarbajanik Sabha' and 'Assam Association' was flexible on the issue of partition of Bengal. They became supporter of partition expecting certain benefits out of it. But at the same time, the role of the leaders like Padmanath Gohain Barua, Ambikagiri Raychoudhury, Triguna Barua, Raktim Bora etc. was different. They were dead against the partition and made propaganda among the Assamese to protest the partition.

In the meantime, the effect of the Swadeshi movement extended up to Assam. The influence of the movement was seen mainly in Dhubri, Gauripur, Goalpara, Guwahati, Tezpur, Dibrugarh etc. town of the Brahmaputra Valley. Asom Keshari Ambikagiri Raychoudhury and Gobinda Lahiri formed revolutionary organization among the students of Guwahati. They called for using



**Ambikagiri
Raychoudhury**

indigenous commodities and boycotting foreign goods in the districts of Assam. The people of Assam used local andi, muga, cotton and khadi cloths instead of foreign cloths. A group of students in Guwahati worked as labour in dock twice in a week and donated the money to the fund of Swadeshi movement thus earned. Ambikagiri Raychoudhury wrote a revolutionary drama named 'Bandini Bharat'. The manuscript of this drama was lifted by the police while it was being performed on the stage of Cotton Collegiate High School, on 31 July, 1906. Ambikagiri established a revolutionary organization Sewa Sangha, with the help of revolutionary activists Khudiram Bose, Barindra Ghose, Ullash Kar Dutta etc. of Calcutta. A bomb was planted on Guwahati-Shillong road targeting to kill J. B. Fuller on 7 Sept, 1906. Ambikagiri was interrogated by the police as the prime suspect of the case. As a result he had to stay at Barpeta as prisoner up to 1914. The British Govt. tried to keep aside the Brahmaputra valley people from the influence of Swadeshi movement. To be successful in this objective, they took up some welfare activities. Some of these are-

1. to introduce Assamese language and literature in the syllabus of entrance examination of Calcutta (Kolkata) University.
2. to open bachelor degrees in all departments in Cotton College to revamp the institution as the centre of excellence.
3. to reintroduce Moujadary system in the Brahmaputra Valley.
4. to introduce 20 point settlement of land.

These are some indirect benefits from Swadeshi movement. The movement became much more popular in the Surma Valley under the leadership of the Surma Valley Association. National Schools were set up at Sylhet, Habiganj, Srimangal, Lakhai, Baniachang, Karimganj, Silchar, and other places.

4.10 : The Non-Cooperation Movement and Assam

The Non-cooperation Movement (Asahayog Andolan) was a major event in the Indian struggle for independence. This movement started in 1920 and lasted through 1922, supported all along by the Indian National Congress. Under Mahatma Gandhi's leadership, the movement aimed to get rid of the British rule through non-violence (ahinsa). When the nation was responding to the call of Gandhi, the Assam Association was not sure about joining the movement. A section of the Association, led by Ganga Gobinda Barua, Tara Prasad Chaliha, Ghanashyam Barua and Chandradhar Barua felt that the Association should retain its separate identity in order to deal with the local issues of Assam. However, the majority felt the need of joining the mainstream politics. At the seventeenth session of the Assam Association held at Tezpur in December 1920, the Association after considerable debate

took the resolution of joining the non-cooperation movement and to follow the directives of the Congress on the matters regarding the movement. The movement in Assam soon merged with the national stream with the formation of the Assam Provincial Congress Committee in June 1921. Kuladhar Chaliha and Nabin Chandra Bordoloi were elected as President and Secretary of the Assam Provincial Congress Committee, respectively.

The Non-cooperation movement in Assam reached its climax with the visit of Gandhi to Assam in August 1921. In all the meetings addressed by Gandhi in major towns were attended by large section of people. Responding to the appeal made by Gandhi people joined boycott movement by organising huge bonfires of British goods. Under the leadership of Chandranath Sarma, Hemchandra Barua, Omeo Kumar Das, Muhibuddin Ahmed, the youth of Assam participated in the movement by boycotting government educational institutions. Some of the prominent youth leaders of the movement were, Lakhidhar Sarma, Rohinikanta Hatibarua, Bimalakanta Barua, Kanak Chandra Barua, Benudhar Sarma, Tilak Sarma and so on. Following the students many lawyers like Nabin Chandra Bordoloi, Kuladhar Chaliha, Tarunram Phukan, Kamini Kumar Chanda, Bishnuram Medhi left their legal practices and joined the movement. Many government officials and teachers also left their jobs. With the growing influence of the movement national schools were opened up at Gauhati, Nalbari, Jorhat, Tezpur, Sibsagar, Nowgong, Karimganj and Maulvibazar. The first national school was established at Gauhati in February 1921, which was named as Tilak Memorial School in the memory of Bal Gangadhar Tilak. This school started functioning from Rohini Kumar Chaudhury's residence at Bharalumukh. Later it was shifted to Assam Club at Uzan Bazar. The leaders of the movement also undertook a programme of constructive works.

One of the major impacts of the movement in Assam was the fall in opium consumption. As a result of the vigorous anti-opium campaign led by the Congress workers the consumption of the abkari opium fell from 1615 maunds in 1920-21 to 993 maunds in 1922-23. The revenue earned from the selling of opium decreased by 19 lakhs rupees. Another important constructive work was popularising the use of khadi and increasing the production of khadi.

The movement witnessed unprecedented support from the tea garden labourers. The large population of tea garden labourers took the opportunity to raise their voice against the colonial exploitation on them.

There were records of sporadic strikes and disturbances. In May 1921, around 8,000 labourers of thirteen tea gardens of the Chargola and Longai valley of Karimganj subdivision came together to protest against their colonial masters under the Congress leadership. Demanding a huge wage increase and accompanied by slogans of '*Gandhi Maharaj Ki Jai*', the labourers came out of their gardens. Unnerved by such exodus of labourers, the planters started pressurising the district administration to use force to bring them back. Hundreds of labourers lost their lives in the turmoil that followed. Others were forced back to their gardens.

4.11 : Civil Disobedience Movement and Assam (1930-34)

Gandhi, who had re-entered active politics in 1928, gave the call for a Civil Disobedience Movement in 1930. Its aim was to paralyse the administration by performance of specific illegal acts. On March 12, 1930, Gandhi along with 78 companions which also included Sarojini Naidu started from Sabarmati Ashram to the sea-coast at Dandi (a distance of 240 miles). At Dandi, he and his followers broke the salt law by preparing salt illegally. The Movement spread rapidly.

In Assam, leaders like Hem Chandra Baruah, M. Tayebullah, Bishnuram Medhi, and Ambikagiri Raychoudhury assembled at Judges' Field at Guwahati and expressed their solidarity with Gandhi's Salt Satyagraha. Leeladhar Barua, then studying at C T College, Calcutta joined the Dandi March. However, at this juncture, the Congress leadership in Assam announced that the province was not ready for a mass movement. Leaders like Tarun Ram Phukan, R.K. Chaudhury and Nabin Chandra Bordoloi were not enthusiastic enough to the Civil Disobedience movement. On the other hand, committed workers like Bishnuram Medhi, Hem Chandra Baruah, Mahammad Tayebullah, and Ambikagiri Raychoudhury were actively engaged in organisational work under severe financial constraints. Under such circumstances, the Congress in Assam needed to be rejuvenated. The task was accomplished under the new leadership of Bishnuram Medhi, Mahammad Tayebullah, and Ambikagiri Raychoudhury. New committees and sub committees were constituted to look into the various matters of the movement. The objectives of the newly formed committees were to raise fund, defiance of repressive laws and ordinances, boycott of the British goods, and anti opium and liquor campaign.

Young leaders like Omeo Kumar Das appealed to the students to join the movement, but response from the students was lukewarm. However,

to protest against the arrest of Nehru on 14 April and Gandhi in 5 May 1930, students participated in hartal in a large number. On 6 and 14 May 1930, students in the Brahmaputra valley resorted to the boycott of their institutions to demonstrate their protest. Meanwhile, the situation became more sensitive when R. J. Cunningham, Director of Public Instruction, issued a circular on May 1930, popularly known as Cunningham Circular asking students and their parents to provide written undertaking guaranteeing that the students would not participate in any kind of political activity. Those found guilty would be punished by imposing fines and depriving of scholarships and also expulsion in case of severe 'crimes'. The students sharply reacted to such humiliating diktat and it further sparked off the Civil Disobedience movement in the region.

The Assam Chatra Sanmilan organised a special session at Gauhati to discuss its plan of action. They decided to picket government institutions. Around 3,117 out of 15,186 students left their institutions between July and August 1930. Picketing was soon extended to opium and liquor shops. Peasants too got engaged in the movement by demanding reduction of land revenue by 50 per cent. Forest laws were also violated in certain areas. Student unrest took place in Surma Valley as well.

4.12 Quit India Movement and Assam

Japan after overrunning Singapore and Rangoon in 1942, was knocking at the very doors of India. Gandhi and the other Congress leaders felt that the presence of the British in India would naturally invite Japan to invade India. Consequently, after much deliberation, the All India Congress Committee in Bombay on August 8, 1942, passed the famous 'Quit India' or '*Bharat Choro*' resolution. Gandhi's speech at the historic August meeting took place at Gowalia Tank in Bombay and this place is now known as the August Kranti Maidan. A great struggle was launched demanding immediate freedom and end of British rule. It was during the course of this movement that Gandhi gave his powerful slogan, 'Do or Die'. People from all walks of life participated in the movement.

The government on its part suppressed the agitation with an iron hand. The Congress party was declared illegal, and its leaders including Gandhi were put behind bars. Thousands were arrested and imprisoned. A large number of people were killed and many more were wounded.



Omeo Kumar Das

Like in other parts of India, in Assam also the major Congress leaders were arrested and the Assam Pradesh Congress Committee, the District Congress Committee and other subsidiary bodies were declared unlawful. All forms of meeting, *hartals*, and gatherings were banned. The movement in Assam started with non-violent methods of *hartals*, processions, demonstrations, and picketing. However, leaders being in jail and with the growing police atrocities the movement turned into rebellion. The people attacked government buildings, destroyed railway tracks and sabotaged military supply lines. Particularly, in Nagaon and Darrang districts, government buildings were regularly attacked and officers were assaulted. There were incidences of sabotage on railways near Shahabibazar in Habiganj, Sarupathar in Golaghat, Panbari and Rangiya in Kamrup and Suffrai in Sibsagar.

Throughout the country, the British responded to the movement by mass arrests and public flogging. Hundreds of innocent people died in this violence and the Congress leadership was cut off from the rest of the world till the war was over. In Assam too, the government started taking stern measures to repress the movement. Kushal Konwar was hanged in connection with derailment of a train at Sarupathar. He was

the only martyr to be hanged in India during the Quit India Movement. Brutal police firings took place at Patacharkuchi (Barpeta), Fakiragram (Goalpara), Dhekiyajuli and Gohpur (both in Darrang districts) killing hundreds of people including a 14 year old girl, Kanaklata Barua of Gohpur.

It was genuinely a mass movement bringing into it hundreds of thousands of ordinary Indians. Isolated incidents of violence broke out around the country, but the British acted quickly and arrested thousands of people and kept them in jail till 1945. Apart from filling up jails with rebellious leaders, the British also went ahead and abolished civil rights, freedom of speech and freedom of press. The brutal repression did end the mass phase of the struggle, but few leaders who had escaped arrest went into hiding and tried to guide the mass movement by consolidating underground networks. Among them were Jai Prakash Narayan, S M Joshi, Aruna Asaf Ali, Ram Manohar Lohia, Achyut Patwardhan and Sucheta Kripalani. In Assam, such



Statue of Kanaklata Barua

underground activities were carried out by Sankar Chandra Barua, Mahendra Nath Hazarika, Jyotiprasad Agarwala, Lakhiprasad Goswami, Brajanath Sarma and Gahan Chandra Goswami. By 1943, there were around 32 underground volunteer camps at Bajali alone. Many such camps were organised in Kamrup, Nowgong, Darrang and Sibsagar.

During the Quit India Movement, parallel governments were formed in a few rural areas in Assam. Village panchayats were established at places like Bajali, Hatisung, Dhakuakhana, Raha, Jamuguri and Bahjani. No – revenue campaign was also carried out vigorously. Despite of the active involvement of the leaderless people in the movement, the movement was snuffed out very soon. By 1944, even when the Congress leaders were still behind bars, the movement was dominated by the Govt. with enormous force. Many nationalists were disappointed that the Quit India Movement had failed.

4.13 Ministry of Gopinath Bordoloi

The elections conducted after the World War II in 1946, the Indian National Congress emerged as the majority party by winning 58 seats out of 108 seats. Thus, Congress formed the government with Gopinath Bordoloi as the Prime Minister (Chief Minister) of Assam. The members of his ministry were Basanta Kr. Das, Bishnuram Medhi, J. Nichols Roy, Ramnath Das, Baidyanath Mukherjee and Abdul Matlib Mazumdar. Till independence Assam hardly had any educational infrastructure. Immediately after independence, the North Eastern region had to face the problem of borderland. In 1947 the partition of India disrupted the communication between the north-eastern region and the rest of India. Only a narrow strip of land of 12 km, joined North-East with the other parts of India. After the partition, railway lines and river transportation between West Bengal and Assam ran through East Pakistan. The partition also disrupted the complex economic ties that existed between Bengal-Assam-Arakan regions. Before the partition, this region (Bengal-Assam-Arakan) enjoyed a dynamic global economy through its agro-industries producing tea, indigo, jute, silk and cotton textiles. After the partition the newly formed states disentangled the global economy in order to build up their own regional economy. Besides economic disruption, the region had to deal with the problem of the immigrants, and geographical reconstruction problem. Thus, the region turned into a geographically isolated area, but at the same time a strategically sensitive area.



Jyotiprasad Agarwala



Gopinath Bordoloi

Under such circumstances, the region focussed on building up its infrastructure along with overall socio-economic growth. Another important task was to develop its human resource as well. Here, we will briefly discuss a few post independence developments of Assam along with the establishment of a few institutions under the leadership of the ministry of Gopinath Bordoloi.

4.13.1 : Assam Agricultural University

The origin of the Assam Agricultural University can be traced back to 1913 when an agricultural research station was established at Karimganj followed by another at Titabar in 1923. Though the stations continued their research and training, yet it became imperative



Main gate of Assam Agricultural University

to have an agricultural and a veterinary college which led to the establishment of the Assam Agricultural College at Jorhat and the Assam Veterinary College at Nagaon in 1948. In 1969, the Assam Agricultural University was established embracing both these Colleges and shifting the Veterinary College from Nagaon to the present location at Khanapara, Guwahati.

Assam Agricultural University was the first institution of its kind in the whole of North-East India. The main objectives of the Assam Agricultural University are:

- To produce globally competitive human resources in farm sector.
- To carry out research in both conventional and frontier areas for production.
- To optimise as well as disseminate the generated technologies as public good.
- To expand the use of technology for benefitting the food growers/producers.
- To maintain a balance among all the stakeholders of agricultural sector while emphasising on sustainability, equity and overall food security at household level.

4.13.2 : Gauhati University (GU)

The University of Gauhati, popularly known as Gauhati University, is the oldest and the first public university of North-East India. It was established on 26 January 1948. That a university could easily be established in Assam was opined by Sir Michael Sedlar, Chairman of the *Calcutta University* Commission in 1917. In the same year, the Assam Association made a public demand for a university at its annual session held at Sibsagar. In 1940 the Government appointed S. K. Bhuyan as Special Officer with the task of collecting relevant information on the selection of site and related matters. The university was established under the Gauhati University Act 1947 of the government of Assam in 1948. The first court meeting of the university was held on 26 January 1948, which is considered as the foundation day, of the university. It had 17 affiliated colleges and eight Post Graduate Departments on its establishment. The University which started functioning from the city centre was shifted to the present campus in 1955-56. Now, the university area is known as Gopinath Bordoloi Nagar.

4.13.3 : Assam Medical College

Assam Medical College situated at Dibrugarh is the first medical college in north-eastern India. The history of the college can be traced back to the Berry White School of Medicine which was established at Dibrugarh in 1900 using a donation of Rs. 50,000.00 from Doctor John Berry White, civil surgeon of the East India Company. In 1910 the college imported two x-ray machines from England. After the Second World War the college was shifted to nearby hospital premises that had been used by the US Army. After independence, on 3 November 1947 the college was formally renamed to become Assam Medical College.

With increasing demands for health care and health education, the need for more medical colleges in Assam was keenly felt. The State Government in 1959 headed by Bimala Prasad Chaliha, the then Chief Minister of Assam, Mr. Fakaruddin Ali Ahmed, the then Finance Minister, and Mr. Rupnath Brahma, the then Health Minister of Assam decided to have a second medical college in Assam. Accordingly, an expert committee was set up on 7 November 1959. The committee submitted its report on 26 April 1960. By a State Government order dated 26 June 1960, Dr. S.N. Sarma, the then Principal and Superintendent of the Assam Medical College & Hospital, Dibrugarh was entrusted with the responsibility to make all necessary arrangements for starting the preclinical classes at Jalukbari from August, 1960 and also for taking



Assam Medical College campus, Dibrugarh

necessary steps for establishment of the proposed medical colleges at Gauhati and Silchar. Accordingly the vacant Ayurvedic College buildings at Jalukbari were taken over and arrangements were started by August, 1960. On the 20 September 1960, the Gauhati Medical College was formally inaugurated. The first batch of the 100 students were interviewed and selected in the AMC, Dibrugarh in the last week of September, 1960. In 1968, Silchar Medical College was also established.

S U M M A R Y

- ☞ By the mid 19th century, Assam like other parts of India witnessed the growth of an English educated middle class. The exposure of the western education led the middle class to look at their society retrospectively. On the one hand, this class moved ahead to reform their society, on the other hand they organised themselves to raise their voice against colonial exploitation. As a result, a number of associations and organisations sprang up. Though the regional aspirations of the leaders of various organisations remained, but with the establishment of strong link with the National Congress by 1920 integrated Assam with the national politics. Thus, Assam made its contribution towards the national movement for independence.
- ☞ At the time of independence Assam was not only facing the problem of the immigrants but also the problem of economic and infrastructural backwardness. Gopinath Bordoloi and his ministry had to deal with such acute problems and made sincere effort to bring about an inclusive development of the region.

EXERCISE

Very Short Answer type Questions :

1. When was the Treaty of Yandaboo signed?
2. Which period is known as Company Raj in Assam?
3. When was Bengali Language introduced in Assam?
4. When was Bengali Language replaced by Assamese language?
5. What was the mouthpiece of Assam Chatra Sanmilan?
6. What was main objective of the Ryot Sabha?
7. When was All Assam Ryot Sabha established?
8. Who was the Secretary of Ahom Sabha?
9. When and under whose leadership was Jorhat Sarbajanik Sabha constituted?
10. Who were the first President and Secretary of Assam Provincial Congress Committee?
11. Who was the first formally elected president of APCC?
12. Who was the first Prime Minister of Assam and when was he elected?
13. On what crime Kushal Konwar was hanged?
14. When was Gauhati University established?
15. When the name Assam Medical College was formally introduced?
16. When was Gauhati Medical College formally started?

Short Answer type Questions :

1. Write a brief note on Assamese Literary Society.
2. Give a brief trace of important nationalist rise in Jonaki Age.
3. Write briefly on the political demands of Ahom Sabha.
4. What were the issues raised by Assam Association before the British Government?
5. Mention about the Assamese leaders who had led the Non-cooperation Movement in Assam.
6. Write about Cunningham Circular.
7. Write briefly about the problems faced by the Ministry of Gopinath Bordoloi after independence.
8. Write brief history of establishment of Assam Agriculture University.
9. Write brief history of establishment of Assam Medical College.

Long Answer type Questions :

1. Discuss the role and activities of Asomiya Bhasa Unnati Sadhini Sabha?
2. Write about the contribution of Assam Chatra Sanmilan.
3. Give an account on the objectives and role of the Ryot Sabhas.
4. Write about the objectives and activities of Jorhat Sarbajanik Sabha.
5. Write on the contribution of Assam Association towards social reform in British ruled Assam.
6. Give brief description on the creation and the role of Assam Provincial Congress Committee.
7. Give brief description on the role of Assam in Swadeshi Movement.
8. Give an account on the role of Assam in Non-cooperation movement.
9. Give an account on the role of Assam in Civil Disobedience Movement.
10. Write about the Quit India Movement in Assam.
11. Give a brief description about the institutions established in Assam under the leadership of Bordoloi Ministry.



CHAPTER-5

CULTURAL HERITAGE OF INDIA AND NORTH EAST REGION

KEY POINTS

- The source of the cultural heritage of India
- Characteristics of Indian culture
- Heritage of Indian culture—literature, architecture, sculpture, arts, music, dances, yoga
- The base of the cultural heritage of the North East Region and Assam
- Cultural Heritage of North East Region — literature, religion, arts, sculpture, architecture, folk culture

5.01 : The source of Cultural Heritage of India

If we need to go into the source of the cultural heritage of India, we have to study the oldest of the civilizations of the country that is Indus Valley civilization. Around 4000 BC, a developed civilization was formed in the Sindhu valley. This civilization included major towns including Harappa and Mahenjodaro and it was extended from Sindhu valley to Meerat in Ganga valley. Many experts are of the view that the Dravidians were the main architects of the Sindhu civilization. Items like statues of Pashupati, Shivalinga, Mother Goddess and seals with symbols of swastika were recovered from different sites of the Indus Valley civilization. Again, discovery of seals having bulls, unicorn, etc. gives an idea that the people were mostly worshippers of totemism.

Historian R. C. Mazumdar was of the view that the Indus valley civilization left its mark on Indian cultural heritage.

The Vedic era started after the fall of the Sindhu civilization around 1500 BC. On the basis of the time of the writing of the oldest written religious book, the Rig Veda, the period between 1500 BC to 1000 BC is considered to be the early-Vedic era, while, the period between 1000 BC to 600 BC is considered to be the later-Vedic era. The other three Vedas (Samhitas) –Yajurveda, Samaveda and Atharvaveda as well as the Upanisadas and Aranyak were written in the later-Vedic era. It is assumed that the Ramayana and Mahabharata were written in the last part of the later-Vedic era. At that time, the Arya culture extended towards the Brahmaputra valley and to Kanyakumari in the south. The Arya culture extended to the entire India by 400 BC.

It is worth mentioning that India now has 705 recognized Scheduled Tribes. According to the 2001 census, as many as 1013 languages are used as mother tongue in India, of which 122 are considered main languages. Altogether 22 languages have been recognized as the state languages by the Constitution of India. Apart from those, more than 3,000 local dialects are used in India.

It is believed that the main architects of the Vedic culture were a group of Nordics who spoke the Aryan language. Before the Dravidians or Mediterraneans and the Nordic Aryans entered India, other groups of people like the Proto- Australoids, Negros, Austrians and then the Mongoloids, and Western Brachcephalic groups of people entered India and started staying in the country. These ethnic groups created many communities and sub tribes in the later stages through assimilation. Similarly several cultural groups of people were created through the assimilation of custom, social tradition, beliefs, rituals and linguistic variations across the groups. The experts have identified a number of contributions of these pre-Aryan groups of people to Indian culture and civilization. For example, cultivation of rice, preparation of molasses from sugarcane, making cloths from cotton etc were the contributions of the Austrians. Similarly, use of sindoor in religious works, use of turmeric, taming of elephants etc. were also the contributions of the Austrians. They also knew how to train wild elephants for domestic use.

At the time when the Arya culture was expanding in India, the social and religious traditions of different areas were also assimilated. As a result, the root of the Aryan culture began to transform. At the same time ethnic tribes also acquired elements of Arya culture and language. In the holy books like the Samhita, Brahman, Aranyak, Ramayana and Mahabharata, Upanishadas and those written in the later stages like the Puran, Smriti, Vedangas etc, these transformation can be witnessed.

During the Indus valley civilization, diverse ways of worshipping could be seen and various Deities (Gods) and Goddesses were worshipped by the people. But at the same time belief in one supreme power (God) also existed in Vedic system. Similarly, the ancient religious tradition of India accepted the principle of tolerance, co-existence and assimilation among new traditions or religions. They also respected reforms, change, even arguments in own beliefs. The religious beliefs in India also added new ways of worshipping over the years and there was no conflict between the Hindus and those following the Buddha and Jain religions. The kings also accepted religious tolerance and Emperor Ashoka had always maintained that no one should consider his or her own religion as superior to others. Rather, peoples should follow a path of unity by acquiring essence of other religions. This message of Ashoka was found in the No.12 main stone writings of Girnar of 3rd century BC. This message bears the oldest witness of religious tolerance of Indian rulers. In later stages, people of different religions like Christian, Islam, Jew, etc entered India. In addition to those main religions, there are a huge number of local ethnic religious faiths practised in India.

Apart from religious differences and co-existence, the spirituality greatly influences the social life, culture and civilization of Indian people. The impact of the religious faiths can be seen in the culture, traditions literature, art, sculpture, architecture, music, dance, painting, morality, values, rituals, festivals and lifestyle of the people of India. The invasion by the Parsi in the sixth century BC, followed by the invasions by the Greeks, Suk, Hun, Turki-Afghan, Portuguese, Moghul, Dutch, French, British etc also had an impact on Indian culture. Many of these people stayed back permanently in India and enriched the Indian culture.

The geographical diversity of India also resulted in diversity of the cultural heritage of the people. Some areas of the vast country have fertile land and the communication system is also much improved. That is why those areas are economically and culturally advanced. While, on the other

hand, some areas do not have these facilities and the people living in such areas have to face a hard life.

The two main characteristics of Indian culture are multi-culturalism and unity in diversity. The multi-culturalism refers to the respect that different groups of people of the country have for each other's cultural heritage and traditions. The term "unity in diversity" was made popular by leaders like Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru, Abul Kalam Azad, Subhash Chandra Bose and others during the time of freedom movement of India. Nehru, in his book, "Discovery of India" also used the term "unity in diversity" and thereby the message was established. Despite the linguistic, religious, geographical and economic diversity, the Indians are tied by a bond of unity. Different factors have been acting to create this unity. The multi-culturalism of Hinduism, political unity created by the empires of different ages, religious and cultural generosity of different rulers have also contributed to this unity. The Ramayana and the Mahabharata also united different parts of the country with the main stream of culture. Moreover, the different groups of the country seem to be tied to each other by cultural exchange. The issues creating diversity, in turn, unites the parts in other way. If two groups are divided geographically, they are being united by language or religion, if some are religiously different, they may be tied geographically or by language.

A few fields of cultural diversity of the vast country India are briefly discussed below.

5.02 : Literature

The old Sanskrit literature of India may be regarded as the soul of Indian culture and civilization. Indian literature is glorified by some great works like-Vedas, Vedangas, Upanishadas like Brahmana and Aranyak, great epics Ramayana and Mahabharata, Gita and Puranas. Politics related book Kautilya's Arthashastra, medicine related book Susruta Samhita, pure literature of Kalidasa, Sudraka, Banabhatta etc. are some bright examples. Philosophical works of Kapil, Patanjali, Gautam, Badarayan, Konad, Jaimini, Ramanuj, Madhbacharya; Historical works like Rajtarangini by Kalhan, scientific works by Aryabhatta, Barahmihir, Brahmagupta, Bhaskaracharya-I and II and Maharshi Bharadwaj; Books like Sangam Sahitya of South India are some great works to recognise the pursuit of knowledge and taste of literature of the Indians. These writings truly reflect the ways of life of the people of that time and their values, beliefs, knowledge in different fields like medical treatment, engineering, science and politics. These books are the result of serious studies, deep insight and tireless intellectual exercise by the great

personalities of that time. These writings also played a great role in shaping the Indian society and brought about a cultural unity. These great books spread values like respect to parents, teachers (Gurus), guests, pursuit of knowledge and scholars and the system of four-casteism in Hinduism. Likewise, concepts of transmigration, liberation (mokshya), heaven and hell, sin-virtue etc. also popularised by these books. Some universal messages like ‘Satyameva Jayate’ from Mundak Upanishad, ‘Ahimsa param dharma’ from Mahabharata, ‘Janani Janmabhumiḥ Swargadapi Gariyasi’ from Ramayana, ‘Basudhaiva Kutumbakam’ from Mohopanishad etc. have been the base of Indian value system. The popular prayer - “Om osato maa sadgamaya, tomaso maa jyotirgamaya, mrityurmaa amritamgamaya” has great influence on Indian psyche. These writings in Sanskrit were later translated into other Indian languages. Great values of these books have been followed in the Indian families hierarchically in terms of group singing (Nam-kirtan), customs and traditions etc. The teachings of these books have been applied by the people as the values of life.

5.03 : Architecture

Temples and other places of worship reflect the architecture of India in ancient times. During the Sultanate and Badshahi era, we get to see at least four types of architecture, that is, Mosques (Masjids), Pillars (Minars), Palaces (Manjils) and Makowara. These architectures were constructed mostly with the patronage of the kings. There are differences in the architectures in North and South India and the difference is more visible on the top half of the structures. Three architectural styles have been seen in the ancient stone temples. These are Nagar in north India, Dravid in south India and Vesara style in between Bindhya mountain and Krishna river. The peaks (Sikhar) of the north Indian temples are semi circular and in south India it is rectangular and gradually smaller rectangulars in shape (Biman) towards the top. Vesara styled temples are mixture of Nagar and Dravid style. Every style is full of many macro and micro artistic skills. In some temples a couple of co-peaks were constructed along with the main peak (Biman) which were gradually declined like peaks of the mountain. Some peaks were designed with lines of statues of Deities. The architecture and art of these temples were very beautiful. The Ajanta cave



Sanchi's Stupa



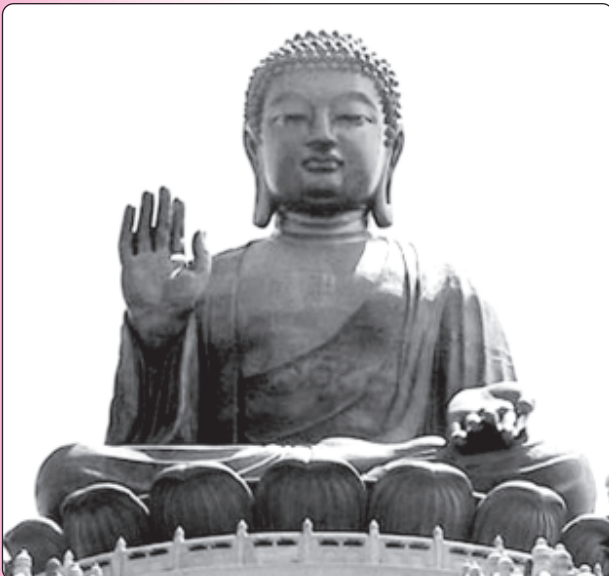
Ashoka Pillar

temples were constructed by cutting stone of Ajanta Hills. The beauty of the front of these temples and technical skills applied in construction also bears testimony to the architectures of ancient India. The temples also have eye catching and beautiful sculptures of the deities and most of the temples were constructed according to the Hindu Vastu. Among a large number of Stupas in the country, the one in Sanchi is said to be the most beautiful and ideal.

Parsi style was used in the architectures during the Turkey, Afghan and Moghul eras. The Taj Mahal constructed during the Moghul period, is considered one of the most beautiful construction during that era. The Taj Mahal along with the caves of Ajanta and Sanchi stupa have been declared the World Heritage Sites by the UNESCO.

5.04 : Sculpture

The Indian sculpture reached the pinnacle of glory during the ancient days and right from the days of Indus Valley civilization, beautiful eye catching sculptures were made. Ancient sculptures were made with soils, stones, bronze, copper, silver and gold etc. The sculptures of ancient India made in own style were also mounted with foreign designs. Among those sculptures some statues were simple, straight and unproportional and others were of proportionally bifurcated, trifurcated and quadrifurcated styles. The feelings of the people like peace, comfort, anguish were reflected in the faces of the statues. Several statues of this kind crafted with micro artistic hands are found in different parts of India. The people made statues of Gautam Buddha, Mahavir, different Gods and Goddesses of the Hindus, fairies and



Statue of Lord Gautam Buddha

even of different animals related to Buddhism. The animal statues crafted on the top of the Ashoka Pillars are closely related to Gautam Buddha's life and these are important elements of Indian culture. Several kings of ancient era patronized the art of making of these sculptures. The sculptures of ancient India can be broadly divided into three major categories, Gandhara, Mathura and Amarawati sculptures. The Gandhar sculptures were developed mainly in North-West Pakistan and East Afghanistan. It had been a living sculpture form from 1st century BC to 7th century. A number of Buddha statues were made by the practitioners of the Gandhar style and Greek-Roman style was also used to build several

Buddha statues. The Mathura style, though developed by itself, was also influenced by the Gandhar style and this style reached its peak during the Gupta era. The Amaravati style was practised for about 600 years from the 3rd century BC. Mainly Satbahanas patronized this art form. Indian sculpture got declined during medeaval period.

5.05 : Paintings

The paintings of ancient India can be broadly divided into two categories—the big wall paintings and smaller paintings. The smaller paintings were used mostly in the books for decoration and pictorial description. Paintings were made in both styles on the walls of Ajanta (Maharastra), Bagh (Madhya Pradesh), Chittanavachal (Tamilnadu), Armamalai (Tamilnadu) caves based on the subject matters of Buddha, Jain and Hindu religions. Among these, Ajanta Cave paintings are world famous. From about 10th century, smaller paintings were done on the barks of Sanchi tree



Ajanta cave painiting

(Sanchipat), silk cloth etc. in places like Assam, Rajasthan, Orissa (Odisha), Mysore (Karnataka), Tanjore etc. These were made mainly for demonstrating pictorial descption of the texts of the books.

In the 1st century B.C. itself, the culture of six skills (saranga) of painting was started. This includes—

(1) shape, (2) measurement, (3) feelings expressing techniques, (4) artistic presentation, (5) knowledge of similarity and (6) rule of using brush. These skills were first applied in wall paintings and later on in smaller paintings also. Colours were made from turmeric, sindur, earth worm etc. natural objects and the paintings were multicoloured. Recently the evidence of painting culture in Parsi style of Sultanate era has been discovered. In Moghul era, mass culture of smaller paintings were done as patronised by Akbar, Jahangir and Sahjahan. This was mainly done in the biographies of Moghul emperors. Among pictorial books of that time the important ones were, Padsahnama, Tutinama, Jahangirnama, Dastan-e-Amir, Khansa etc. Parsi style of painting was also used in the pictorial descriptions of Hindu religious books like the Ramayana and the Mahabharata. The paintings of Moghul era were done on the subjects like portrait of Kings,

Darbars, war wining, hunting, garden, flower, animals etc. and these were found very skillful.

5.06 : Music and Dances

India has a rich cultural heritage in music. The slokas of Sam Veda were read like song by the priests named ‘Udgata’ for the appeasement of the deities. In later stage, ‘Udgata’s were divided into various groups depending on their changing styles of singing of slokas.

The Mentor-disciple (Guru-sishya) tradition in classical music is still prevalent in India as a strong tradition. This tradition reached a high standard during Moghul period. Along with the music, different types of musical instruments were invented to accompany classical and folk music. Among those instruments shehnai, tabla, santur, sitar, beena, flute, dhol, taal, nagara, mridanga, khol, nupur, sharinda, dotara etc. were important.

These musical instruments are still popular India and certain classical instruments like sitar, flute, beena, tabla etc. are becoming more popular abroad. Like music, dances have also a rich tradition in India. Of the hundreds of traditional dances in the nook and corner of the country, eight dances have been recognised by the Govt. of India as the Indian Classical Dance forms. These are – Kathakali (Malayalam, Kerala), Mohiniyattam (Kerala), Bharatnatyam (Tamilnadu), Kuchipudi (Andhra Pradesh), Odissi (Odisha), Kathak (Northern India), Manipuri (Manipur) and Satriya (Assam).



**Satriya Dance
of Assam**

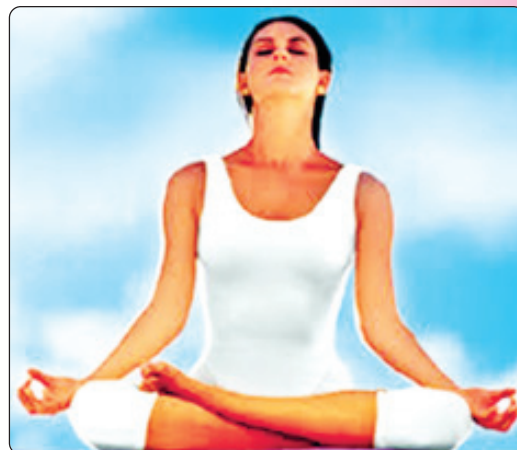


Manipuri classical dance of Manipur

The Natyashastra by Bharat Muni was written between 200 BC to second century. In the Natyashastra, different rules of drama, music and dances were outlined in around 6000 slokas

5.07 : Yoga Culture

Yoga is a traditional Indian culture and it is a gift to the entire humanity. It is believed that the Indians were experts in yoga even during the Indus Valley civilization and it was widely practised during the Vedic era. This traditional practice was brought into a standard by Maharshi Patanjali by compiling a book called Yogasutra in the second century. He described yoga as a way of physical, mental and spiritual well being. He shaped yoga as a complete way and philosophy of life.



Yoga



A view of the International Yoga Day celebrated in New Delhi on 21 June, 2015

There are 'Astanga' Yoga rule in Patanjali yoga system named Yama, Niyama, Asana, Pranayama, Pratyahar, Dharana, Dhyan and Samadhi. Keeping in view the benefits of yoga, the United Nations has declared 21 June as the International Yoga Day.

5.08 : North East

The term North East was coined by the British rulers of India. The states of the region—Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram,

Cultural heritage of India and North East Region



Tripura, Meghalaya and Assam, each has traditional and distinctive cultural heritage and political history. At the same time, the states of the region have some common features and giving recognition to that, the Government of India has formed the North Eastern Council. However, Sikkim is also included in the North Eastern Council.

The north-eastern region has got a different common identity due to its unique geographical boundary. The fertile Brahmaputra and Barak Valley plain being in the middle, the other states have been distributed in the north, south and east. The region is again surrounded by the foreign countries Bhutan, China, Myanmar and Bangladesh. All neighbouring

states are hilly. Due to this type of natural setting, Assam is used by all the states as the central place for comfortable transport connection. It is believed that a civilization grew in the Brahmaputra valley even in the pre-historic days, but written history is available after the Barman rulers assumed power in the 4th century. The rulers of the neighbouring states sometimes expressed their subordination or sometimes obeyed to the rulers of the powerful royal families of Assam in different times. Information on above relationship between the neighboring states during the reign of Ahom royal families (1228 - 1826 A.D), is found in the histories written in that age. The ruling families had ties with each other through marriages and during the time of crisis, the kingdoms helped each other with military might. Communication was set up among the kingdoms through messengers (dut). Barter of different items also took place between kingdoms. Thus unity and integrity among the people were set up. Majority of the people of the region belong to the Mongoloid group, while, the Khasis of Meghalaya belong to the Austric group.



Hornbil festival of Nagas

During the British days, the Missionaries started expanding Christianity in the North East, particularly in the hill states, while, the Hindu religion established roots in the area during ancient times. Hinduism was expanded in Manipur and Tripura in ancient times. It may be mentioned here that several tribes of the region

still follow the Animist traditions. For example, some tribes of Arunachal Pradesh follow the Hindu, Christian and Buddha religions but at the same time they also worship Doney Polo, that is their popular Deities, the Sun and the Moon. Hornbil is one of the most popular festivals in Nagaland and it is celebrated



Khasi dance

in the first ten days in the month of December where all the tribes showcase their traditional and rich cultural heritage. As the Nagas believe the bird hornbill to be sacred, the festival is named after the bird. Freedom fighter

Rani Gaidalu launched a movement named 'Heraka' for the revival and preservation of the traditional religious beliefs and cultural heritage of the tribes of Nagaland. Majority of the Maitei people of Manipur are followers of Chaitanya's cult. The impact of Vaishnava religion is seen in their rich cultural heritage. Songs,



Cheraw dance of Mizos

dances and musical instruments influenced by Vaishnava religion are seen among the Manipuris. The Manipuri Dance form developed mainly on the basis of the childhood of the saint Chaitanya, and of Lord Krishna etc.

is recognised as a classical dance by the Sangeet Natak Akademy, Govt. of India. Some of the people of Manipur still follow the Animist way of life. Majority of the people of Tripura are Hindus and impact of Bengali culture is seen in the state. However, the culture of Tripura is a mixed culture enriched with the elements of various tribes. The Khasi, Garo and Jaintia people of Meghalaya started following Christianity from 1830 and now more than 70 percent people of the state are Christians. Around 80 percent of people of the state depend on agriculture and a number of them are



Stilt house (Chang ghar) of Mizos

involved in jhum cultivation like other hill states. Meghalaya has a matriarchal society and various tribes of Maghalaya have been able to preserve their traditional cultural heritage. Mizoram has different tribes and sub tribes and they are called the Mizos together. The term Mizo means inhabitants of the Hills. Majority of the people of the state are Christians but some follow Buddhism and Hinduism. After transforming in to Christian, Mizo traditional culture and festivals began to diminish. But since 1973, they restarted to observe traditional festival ‘Chapchar Kut’. Along with this, Mizos have made efforts to revive many other traditional dance, music etc.

Many tribes are found in N.E. states, living with their heirarchial families and branches of families developed in due course. So a colourful culture is seen in every state with different traditional dresses, dances, songs, instruments (musical), festivals, dialects, beliefs etc. of each community. Every state has practices like jhum cultivation, drinking of local wines, non-vegetarian foods, village administration, stilt houses made of bamboo and wood etc. The hill peoples are generally hard worker, self dependent and courageous because of their hard life and livelihood.

5.09 : Assam

Among the states of the North East region, Assam has the most varied cultural traditions and mixture of cultures. Assam is rich in natural resources and the fertile land, particularly in the Brahmaputra valley added to the richness of the state. At one point of time, Assam was connected with China by great Silk Route, while, China was connected to the Roman Empire through Assam. From ancient times, different groups of people came to Assam for various reasons—for doing business, for pilgrimage and even as invaders and some stayed back in the state.

As already mentioned that the main ethnic groups of people in India are also found in Assam and the process of cultural assimilation also happened in Assam as occurred in India. As a result, a mixed culture was developed in Assam with the integration of Arya and Anarya. The old name of Assam was Pragjyotishpur and Kamrup. These names are found in old writings including the Ramayana, Mahabharata, Vishnu Puran, Kalika Puran, Yoginitantra, writings of Hiuen Tsang and even in the inscriptions of ancient Royal families. These two Sanskrit words have connected Assam to the Hindu mythology or Hindu astrology. Noted scholar Banikanta Kakati was of the view that the words Pragjyotishpur and Kamrup originated from similar words in the Austric language. The Ahoms ruled the state from the 13th century.

Some experts opined that the name Assam (Asom) emerged from sanskritization of the words ‘a-cham’ and ‘ha-chom’ used by the Ahom and the Bodo people respectively.

5.10 : Literature

The Barman dynasty established in the middle part of the 4th century and the following royal dynasties first used Sanskrit and later on Assamese (evolved from Sanskrit) as the official language. However, the modern Assamese language has been formed after crossing various stages from the time of evolving from Sanskrit. From the scriptures of Barman dynasty, Salastambha dynasty, Paul dynasty, Koch royal dynasty and Ahom scriptures this fact comes out. However, the Ahoms used their own Tai language. The modern form of Assamese language has been developing from the time of the first Assamese Journal ‘Arunodoi’.

During the period from 10th to 14th century, the only written Assamese literature was mostly a collection of songs called Charyapada. In the 14th century, Hem Saraswati, Rudra Kandali, Haribar Bipra, Kaviratna Saraswati and Madhab Kandali created literature in verse form based on Purana and other ancient Indian epics. Madhab Kandali was patronized by Barahi King Mahamanikya. Other scholars were patronized by the kings of Kamata. It is important to mention that Madhab Kandali translated the Ramayana into Assamese, titled ‘Saptakanda Ramayana’, which was the first work of translation from Sanskrit into a North Indian language.

The Vaishnavite movement launched by Sankaradeva and Madhabdeva in the 15th century influenced the life of the people of Assam in all aspects. This religious movement had a major impact on Assamese literature and a lot of poetry, songs, prose, charit puthi, drama etc. were written during that time. The main subject matters of these literary works were Ramayana, Mahabharata, Purana, theories of Hindu religion etc. Sankaradeva and Madhabdeva themselves wrote a number of classics. Sankaradeva’s Kirtan, Madhabdeva’s Namghosha and the Borgeets of both the gurus were most popular among these.

The plays (Ankiya Naats) of Sankaradeva- Patniprasad, Kaliya Daman, Keli Gopal, Rukmini Haran, Parijat Haran, Ram Bijay; Dadhi Mathan of Madhabdeva and his Jhumuras ‘Chordhara’ and ‘Pimpura Guchowa’ etc. are presented before huge gathering of spectators at Namghar and Satras. The first naat (drama) Chihnajatra of Sankaradeva was even written and staged before Shakespeare’s drama. The famous



The first Assamese Magazine– Arunodoi

textile design of Sankardeva the Brindabani Bastra was a magnificent creation of the Assamese weavers. This textile design has been preserved in British museum and in a few other famous museums in parts.

After Sankardeva and Madhabdeva, prominent writers like Bhattadeva, Ananta Kandali, Ram Saraswati and other kept up the tradition of Assamese literature. The real Assamese prose writing was first introduced by Bhattadeva with his writings like Katha Geeta, Bhagawat Katha, Ratnawali Katha etc.

Staying away from the ambit of the Sankari style of writing, writers like Pitambar Kavi, Durgabar Kayastha, Su-kabi Narayandeva, Mankar and others also enriched Assamese literature. They composed story based on lyrics like Devi Manasaa, Padmaa, Sati Beula etc. The “Padya Geeta” written by Govinda Mishra born in 16th century is still widely popular.

The histories written under the patronage of the Ahom kings also enriched Assamese literature. First those were written in the own language of Ahoms, but from the 16th century onwards, those were written in Assamese language also. During the British rule, a number of such histories were restored, preserved and printed. Those include Deodhai history, Tungkhungiya history, Kachari history, Jayantiya history, Tripura history, Padya history, Padshyah history etc. The modern Assamese language evolved after the American Baptist Missionaries published the first Assamese magazine Arunodoi in 1846. Gradually, the Assamese literature was influenced by various styles and characteristics of European literature.

5.11 : Religion

Majority of the people of Assam are Hindus. They are followed by people following Islam, Christian, Jain, Buddha, Sikh and other religions. The people following Hindu religion in Assam can be broadly divided into those following “Sakta”, “Shaiva”, “Vaishnav” and “Sourya” cults. There are several Saktipithas in Assam. Among those the Kamakhya temple in the state is famous all over the world. The neo Vaishnavite movement resulted in a large number of people of



Kamakhya temple of Guwahati

the State following Vaishnavism. Trace of Islamic religion was first found in Assam in the 13th century. Poa Macca in Hajo is a holy place of Islamic people. The Zikir and Zari written by Ajan Peer (Sah Milan) are popular religious songs. Ajan Peer came to Assam during the reign of Gadadhar Singha. During the invasion of the Burmese (Mans), Ranjit Singh of Punjab sent a group of Sikh soldiers to assist Ahom King Chandrakanta Singha. Some of them stayed back in the state and though their descendants now follow the Sikh religion, they have become Assamese by accepting Assamese culture. Some of the people living in the eastern part of the state including Tai Phake, Turung, Aitan, Khamti, Khamyang, Nora (Shyam), etc follow Buddha religion. The Ahom kings followed a secularist outlook and they patronised for setting up places of worship of different religions.



Poa Macca (Mecca) in Hajo.

5.12 : Art and Paintings

Paintings in Assam started to take proper shape from the 17th century onwards mainly with the patronage of the kings, while, the pictorial books were developed in the satras like small pictured books of North India. Most famous pictorial books of that time include Hastibidyarnava, Ananda Lahari, Chitra Bhagawat, Geet Govinda, Kumor Haran, Sankhachur Badh, Lava Kushar Yuddha etc. written on Sanchipat. The multi-coloured pictures were drawn with natural colours. A certain colour was painted on the Sanchipat first, then pictures of kings, palaces, deities, animals etc. were drawn as



The famous pictorial book Geet Govinda



Hastibidyarnava



Pictorial book on Sanchipat

per the demand of the subject matter. The blank spaces were filled with flower, cripples etc. The colours mostly used were red, green, yellow and black. The book *Hastibidyarnava* written by Sukumar Borkaith had huge number of pictures of elephants of different sizes and colours. The pictures in the book were drawn by two artists named Dilbar and Dosai. Later, several of those books were published in print.

5.13 : Sculptures

A huge number of sculptures are seen mainly on the temples in Assam. Some of these are two-dimensional wall statues and others are three



Old sculpture of Madan Kamdev temple

dimensional complete statues. The sculptures were made of stones as well as with elephant trunk, gold, silver, copper and wood etc. The sculptors mostly made sculptures of different deities like Shiva, Vishnu, Ganesha, Surya etc. while, sculptures of lion, sun, elephant, horses etc. are also seen. Examples of beautiful sculptures of Assam can be seen in places like Da-Parbatia in Tezpur, Bamuni Pahar, Madan Kamdev, Ambari, Dabaka, Surya Pahar, Borganga, Numaligarh, Deopani, Hojai, Dibrugarh, Sukreswar, Paglatek of Goalpara, Mangoldoi etc. Though the Ganga Yamuna statue in the stone gate of Da-Parbatia is smaller in size, from the artistic view point it is well appreciated. The Da-parbatia sculptures were made in 6th century influenced by Gupta sculptures.

5.14 : Architecture



Shiva DouL of Sivasagar

Majority of the old architectures in Assam were constructed in the middle age and in the patronage of the Ahom and Koch kings. The famous of the architectures of that time including Rong Ghar, Kareng Ghar, Talatal Ghar and a number of temples built by the Ahom kings still bear testimony to the architecture of that time. The most famous of the temples constructed during that time include Kamakhya, Ugratara, Umananda, Shiva DouL, Joy DouL, Devi DouL, Fakua DouL, Haygrib-Madhab temple of Hajo, Sukreswar-Devalaya Temple, Shiva temples in Dergaon and Bishwanath, Navagraha etc. temples. The temples were commonly of Nagara

or Vesara style. The architectures of that time were made with stones and bricks.

The construction of the multi-storied Talatal Ghar was started by Ahom King Rudra Singha and it was later completed by Rajeshwar Singha and the kings following him. The Rong Ghar was constructed in two storied form for enjoying celebration of the Bihu festival in the courtyard. The roof of the Rong Ghar was made in the style of a play-boat (Khel-nao). A number of stone bridges were also constructed during the time of the Ahom kings. Of those, the bridges at Namdang, Darika and Dinjoy are still being used.

In Ahom period, one indigenous type of concrete (pulp) was made by mixing eggs, rice (Bora), cat fish etc. materials for framing the bricks. There was an officer called Changrung Phukan to supervise the construction and measurements of the roads, palaces, temples, houses etc. The histories written on the activities of the Changrung Phukan is called the Changrung Phukan's history.



Talatal Ghar of Sivasagar



Rong Ghar of Sivasagar with Bihu dance

5.15 : Folk Culture

Assam has a very rich cultural heritage. In addition to the common cultural heritage, every tribe and sub tribes have their own rich traditional cultural heritage. Every tribe has its own dialects, folk-literatures,



Karbi dance



Rabha folk dance - Pharkanti



Bodo folk dance - Bagurumba



Tiwa dance

ornaments, food habits, housing culture, agriculture, fishing culture, various festivals, style of using cane & bamboo, family & social relationships, customs and traditions, dresses, music, traditional musical instruments etc. The natural feelings and expressions of a society or community is reflected by its folk culture. These traditional cultures practised for years are acquired by the people without any formal training. But a person can understand the tradition of other's culture through special observation only. Of late, the social scientists have shown keen interest in the traditional folk cultures of different groups of people of the world.

A few elements of folk culture of Assam are briefly discussed below :

Bihu festival of Assam :



Garu bihu– the bihu festival of cow

Bihu is the community festival of Assam. Three bihu festivals are observed in Assam– Bohag (Rangali) bihu, Kati (Kongali) bihu and Magh (Bhogali) bihu are observed in the months of Bohag (Baishag), Kati (Kartik) and Magh respectively.

Bihu is celebrated by all people of Assam with traditional gaiety. The Bohag Bihu is celebrated from the last day of Assamese month of Sot (Chait) to the first six days of Bohag. The last day of the Sot month is called the Sankranti or Domahi and that day is observed as “garu bihu” (bihu festival for the cows). Cows

are an important part in the life of the Assamese people, who mostly depend on agriculture and that is why the day is dedicated in the name of cows. Cows are specially treated on that day. On that day, cows are given a good bath in the rivers and ponds. The first day of the month of Bohag is called “Manuh bihu” (bihu for the human). People wear new cloths on that day and the younger ones seek blessings from the



Bihu dance

elders. Different sports and cultural activities are organized in public places. Bihu naam (Huchari) followed by bihu dance are performed by the groups of people in all houses. The hosts welcome them and seek blessings. The women of Upper Assam perform typical Jeng bihu. Different Communities of Assam observe Bahag bihu with their own style in a befitting manner. Bodo, Rabha, Karbi, Missing, Deuri, Tiwa etc. communities have different dresses, songs customs to observe bihu in a very colourful manner. The vast Assamese culture means these multicolour cultures of all ethnic groups of people. The people also greet each other with “Bihuwans”. Different tribes of the state also observe Bihu with their own traditional ways.

Some of the old traditions of observing Bihu are not seen in modern times. Instead, cultural programmes and different sports activities are organized in public places in towns and cities. Perhaps, Ahom King Rudra Singha first organized Bihu in public place by organizing the festival in the courtyard of Rong Ghar. During the British rule, some of the conservative Assamese people looked down upon the love songs sung in Bihu, but at the same time, some persons with modern outlook brought Bihu to the towns by organizing the festival on open stage.

The bihu dance is accompanied by some instruments like Dhol (Drum), horn pipe (pepa), flutes (siphong of Bodos), gagana etc., which are different in different communities. Some other festivals are observed in some places which are homogenous to Bahag bihu. Among those, Deul in Darrang, Bhatheli, Suweri, Bar Gopal etc. in old (undivided) Kamrup, Baash puja in Goalpara are important.

Kati Bihu is observed on the last day of Assamese month of Ahin. People observe fasting in the day and light lamps under Tulsi and in paddy fields in the evening. Sky lamps (Akash Banti) are also lit in the paddy fields. Bodo people lit lights under Cactus (Siju) tree with holiness. Some religious faiths are also associated with these traditions.



Haystack (Meji) of Magh bihu

Magh Bihu or Bhogali Bihu is celebrated on the last day of the Assamese month of Push. The day before the Bihu is called Uruka. People construct bhelaghar (temporary hut made of bamboo, straws etc.) and meji in fields and community feasts are organized near those on the night of Uruka. In the morning of the day of Bihu the mejis are set on fire and people take blessings from the God of Fire. People also prepare different traditional snacks, sweets, jalpan etc. in the festival and receive guests. During the time of Magh, all types of food become available. The Magh bihu is called ‘Bhogali’, because people observe this festival with heavy food enjoyment, i.e., bhoga.

Various festivals are observed in different parts of India, which are similar to Bahag, Magh and Kati bihu festivals of Assam. A cultural assimilation of different tribes and communities is reflected in bihu festivals of Assam.

Folk Songs:

Assam has a rich tradition of folk songs, which are sung on different occasions and in different environments. Some of these have been obsolete and others are flowing with force. Marriage songs (biya naam), appeasing song (nisukani geet) Kamrupi and Goalparia folk songs are most popular among other folk songs like Aainam, Dhainaam, Dotara (tokari) song, chiyageet, Nangeli geet (cow-boy song), cherradhek etc.

A number of folk song artistes of the state including Khagen Mahanta, Rameswar Pathak and Pratima Pande Baruah have been honoured with the Sangeet Natak Akademi awards, while, Pratima Pande Baruah, a prominent Goalparia folk song artiste was also awarded the Padma Sree by the Government of India.

In addition to the folk songs, Assam also has a rich tradition of folk dances and Ojapali is one of the most popular among those. Ojapali has two styles– Byash oja and Sukannani oja. Stories of Ramayana and Mahabharata are sung in Byash, while in Sukannani, story is sung for

appeasement of Manasa Devi. Ojapali is more popular in the districts of Kamrup, Nalbari, Barpeta and Darrang. Two popular ojapali performers— Lalit Chandra Nath and Kinaram Nath were awarded the Sangeet Natak Akademi awards. The other most popular of the folk dances include Dhepadhulia, Bordhulia, Deodhani of Darrang, Mohoho, Bhortal dance, Thiyanaam, Ojapali etc. of Lower Assam, Dhulia ojapali, Jhumur of Upper Assam etc.



Bhortal dance

The whole society is like a book to study the folk culture of it. To know valuable elements of folk culture, one has to observe the activities and behaviours of the common people of the society.

S U M M A R Y

- ☞ Indus valley civilization has a significant contribution towards formation of Indian culture and Hindu religion. The Vedic and Arya culture, integrated culture of Buddha, Jain, Christian, Islam are the important features of Indian culture.
- ☞ Multi culturalism and unity in diversity are two main characteristics of Indian culture. Four Vedas and the Ramayana and the Mahabharata are some great elements of Indian culture.
- ☞ The architecture of Ahom period has covered the major portion of the history of architectural arts of Assam.
- ☞ The folk culture of Assam means the diverse cultural heritage of all sections of people including the tribes and sub tribes.

EXERCISE

Very short answer type questions :

1. What was the eastern border of the Indus Valley civilization extended up to Ganga Valley?
2. When was the town culture developed during the Indus Valley civilization?
3. What was the presumed time of writing of the Rig Veda?
4. The term Satyameva Jayate in the National symbol was taken from which book?
5. Which book did establish the term 'unity in diversity'?
6. Greek-Roman techniques were used in which style of sculptures of India?
7. What is the name of the famous book on political science written in ancient India?
8. When was the Natyasastra by Bharat Muni written?
9. How many slokas are there in the Natyashastra ?
10. What is Heraka movement?
11. Hornbill festival of Nagaland is based on which name of organism?
12. The traditional festival Chapchar Kut belong to which state?
13. What is the meaning of the word Mizo?
14. Which state of the North East has a matriarchal society?
15. What is the main theme of Manipuri dance?
16. What is the ancient name of Assam?
17. From which Bodo word the name Assam is considered to be derived?
18. What is Charyapada?
19. When was the Charyapada written?
20. Under whose patronage did Madhab Kandali translate the Saptakanda Ramayana?
21. Who was the first to introduce prose literature in Assamese?
22. Who composed Zikir and Zari?
23. Who is Ajan Peer?
24. When did Ajan Peer come to Assam?
25. When was the stone gate of Da-Parbatia made?
26. What was the duty of the Changrung Phukan?
27. Which artist got Padmashree award for the contribution in folk song?
28. What is the name of the first news magazine of Assam?
29. Which tribe of North East is a part of the Austric ethnic group?
30. Name the writers of the books : *Arthashastra*, *Hashtividyarnava*, *Kirtan*, *Naamghosa*, *Chordhora aru Pimpara Goshowa*, *Kaliya Daman*, *Ramvijoy*, *Katha Geeta*, *Rajtarangini*, *Bharat Sambhed*.

Short answer type questions :

1. Write the names of two foreign communities which came to India after 6th century.
2. Name two statues used for worshipping and which were discovered during Indus Valley civilisation.
3. Mention two contributions of the Austriacs to Indian culture.
4. How does the geography of India play a role in creating cultural diversity of India?
5. Write the names of the four Samhitas of the Vedas.
6. What is written about religious tolerance in the 12th main stone carvings of Ashoka?
7. What is multiculturalism?
8. What are the divisions in the ancient Indian culture?
9. Write names of two scientists in ancient India.
10. Write names of two medical books written in ancient India.
11. Write names of two Moghul emperors who patronized arts.
12. Write names of two pictorial books written in "Sanchipat" in Assam.
13. Write the names of the two painters of Hastibidyarnava.
14. What is jhum cultivation?
15. What is Zeng bihu?
16. Write two divisions of Ojhapali.
17. Write names of two philosophers of ancient India.
18. Write names of two histories written during the Ahom era.
19. Write the names of two homogenous festivals of Bihu celebrated in lower Assam.
20. Write names of two folk dances of Darrang.
21. What are the main ethnic groups of India?
22. Write three factors that create unity among cultural diversity in India.
23. What are the main divisions made for the Indian architectural setup?
24. Write names of three architectural setup of India which are declared as World Heritage Site by the UNESCO.
25. What statues were mainly created in the field of Indian sculptures?
26. What are the three main styles of Indian Sculptures?
27. Name three pictorial books of Moghul age.
28. What are the six skills (sorangas) of paintings?
29. Write about three places of India having ancient wall paintings.
30. Write briefly on the culture of Yoga in India.
31. By what names the first seven days of Rongali Bihu are commonly known?

32. What are the main subject matters of Kamrupi and Goalparia folk songs?
33. Name three books where the ancient names of Assam– Kamrup and Pragjyotishpur are mentioned.

Long answer type questions :

1. Write briefly on the source and development of multi-culturalism in India.
2. The soul of Indian culture and civilization is regarded to be existed in the Sanskrit literature of ancient India– discuss the meaning of the sentence.
3. Write about religious traditions in India.
4. Write how the common and separate identity of the North-East is developed.
5. Write briefly about the religious environment in the North-East.
6. Assam has a mixed culture due to assimilation of Aryan and non Aryan cultures— discuss briefly this aspect.
7. Write briefly on the heritage of paintings in Assam.
8. Write about religious unity and diversity in Assam.
9. Why the cultural diversity, assimilation and change are taking place more rapidly in Assam than the other states of the region?
10. Really the society is like a book for studying the folk culture– provide your views on this issue.

Write short notes on:

1. Sculptures of ancient India.
2. Indian paintings.
3. Traditions of songs and dances in India.
4. Sculptures of Assam.
5. Architectures of Assam.
6. Vaishnavite literature of Assam.
7. Folk songs of Assam.
8. Religious unity in Assam.
9. Historical literature of Assam.
10. Bihu festival.